

THE PERFECT JOSEPH AND GUMBALL:

THE MULTIVERSAL SAGA

PART TWO:

THE DEVIL YOU DON'T KNOW

Written by Youssef Boutahri

Based on the novel 'The Perfect Joseph and Gumball –
Absolute Legendary Edition'

Directed by Christopher Nolan

*"The evil you cannot see is not in power.
It is in the architecture."*

Runtime: 3 Hours 55 Minutes

Production Budget: \$425,000,000

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COLD OPEN: THE ARCHITECTURE OF POWER

DARKNESS.

Complete. Total. The darkness of a mind turned entirely inward – the dense, pressurized darkness of a man who has nothing left but thought, and has decided to treat that as the greatest advantage of his professional career.

A single sound: the faint scratch of a fingernail tracing a line in the grout between tiles. Precise. Rhythmic. Unhurried. The sound of someone who has all the time in the world and has made a considered choice about how to use it.

We hold on the darkness.

We hold on it longer than is comfortable.

The scratching continues.

FADE IN:

INT. COSMIC VAULT – CELL BLOCK X – NIGHT (EIGHTEEN MONTHS AGO)

A cell. White walls, white floor, white ceiling. The deliberate, relentless whiteness of an environment designed by people who understood that the most effective form of sensory deprivation is not darkness but sameness – the removal of reference points, the stripping of the mind of the anchor of external variation, the forcing of consciousness back onto itself as its only landscape.

Some men dissolve under this. Most do.

There is a cot. Bolted to the wall.

There is a table. Bolted to the floor.

There is a man. Neither bolted nor dissolved. This is not regulation.

JEFFREY EPSTEIN – sixty-three years old, wearing the facility's standard-issue grey – sits on the cot with his

hands folded in his lap. He is not reading. He is not pacing. He is not staring at the ceiling or performing any of the behaviors the human mind reaches for when stripped of everything that normally fills it.

He is thinking.

He has been thinking for eighteen months without stopping. This is, he has concluded, the most productive period of his professional life.

Consider what he had before: an operation of extraordinary complexity – twenty-three nodes, hundreds of active relationships, daily demands on his attention from people who needed him to be different things simultaneously. Extraordinary. But the demands of running it had prevented him from ever seeing it whole.

Now he can see it whole.

He has been examining it from every angle for eighteen months. He has found the inefficiency: a redundancy between nodes fourteen and seventeen that appears to be structural strength but is, on closer examination, a single point of coordinated failure. Corrected, the entire system becomes more resilient.

He has corrected it. On the far wall – in lines so faint they look like the natural imperfections of old grout, in a notation system he developed himself over the first three months – he has the improved architecture. Twenty-three nodes. Revised connections. The system as it will be when he walks out of here.

When he gets out – and he has always known he will get out; the only question has ever been timing – it will be better than before.

He makes a small final correction. He leans back.

He is smiling.

The smile is the most frightening thing in the room. There is no one here to see it. This is not a problem. He has never needed an audience.

INT. COSMIC VAULT – CELL BLOCK X – THREE MONTHS LATER

The same cell. The same man. Eighteen months have refined him the way a whetstone refines a blade – taking off what is unnecessary and leaving only the edge.

A small screen in the corner shows a SURVEILLANCE FEED playing on loop – the product of a guard whose financial circumstances Epstein researched precisely before entering this facility, because Epstein always researches the people around him, always, as a matter of professional reflex that has never failed to reward him.

The feed: a boy on the ice at Antarctica. Approximately twenty years old. Pressing his palms flat against the ice. Golden light erupting from the point of contact. The impossible, documented, undeniable power of the being they are calling the Ideal.

Epstein has watched this footage four hundred and twelve times.

He is not watching the power. He has seen power before. He has spent his entire career in proximity to power. Power announces itself, makes itself visible, operates in the open because visibility is part of its function.

He is watching the architecture beneath the power.

He pauses the footage at the moment the boy falls backward – the instant after the transmission, when the energy has left him and he is simply twenty years old and needs to be caught. He studies the frame.

He notes: a young man with a bandaged hand catches him. SEIKO TOAST, twenty, the analytical core of the support system. Remove him and the Ideal operates effectively blind.

He notes: a young woman reaching. YARA GORDON, twenty-one. The emotional architecture. The person who knows how to hold the Ideal through the moments when being extraordinary is insufficient. Remove her and the Ideal is alone inside his own head.

He notes: visible in briefing photographs, an older man – HASSAN AL-MITHALI – his hands flat on a kitchen table in Casablanca, providing across international distance the baseline sense of continuity that grounds the Ideal's operational identity.

He notes: FATIMA AL-MITHALI. Apartment 4B, Rue des Orangers, Maarif district, Casablanca. A cream-colored building with jasmine on the south wall. An electrical system installed in 1987.

He closes the file.

He reads it the way an architect reads a load-bearing analysis — looking not at what is there, but at what, if removed, would cause the structure above it to shift.

He finds it.

He goes back to watching the boy on the ice.

EPSTEIN

(to the screen — the voice of
someone who has been having
this conversation with
himself for weeks and has
reached the conclusion)

You're not the source. You said so
yourself. On the ice. You said:
I'm the transmitter.

He studies the frozen face on the screen. The face of
someone who has never had to calculate the cost of love.

EPSTEIN

(continuing — very quiet,
very precise)

Then let us find the source. And let
us see what happens to the transmitter
when the source is removed. When the
current finds no ground to flow into.
When the wire discovers what it is
without what it carries.

He leans back.

He is smiling.

CUT TO:

EXT. SOMEWHERE OUTSIDE TIME — CONTINUOUS

No floor. No ceiling. No horizon. The non-space of a consciousness that exists in multiple moments simultaneously — not a location but a condition.

KRONOS — seven feet of compressed, ancient power — stands in nothing with the patience of something for whom impatience has never been a meaningful concept. His cloak moves with the rhythm of the event horizon. His eyes: gold without pupils, recording rather than perceiving.

Before him: the TEMPORAL LATTICE. The structure of how moments connect to other moments. How choices cascade into consequence. How causality weaves itself into what we call history.

He is studying a specific thread. The thread that begins at a specific address in Cambridge on a specific night in September.

He has been tracing this thread for three years. In ten thousand years, he has always been able to see past a given point in any timeline. This thread creates a region of opacity beyond a certain point — the specific static of something that has not yet decided what it will be.

He has studied this opacity.

His conclusion: the opacity is caused by the boy's nature. Not his power — his nature. The boy makes decisions that emerge from a quality of attention to other people that no predictive model can fully simulate. The relationship is the variable. The relationship is the unpredictable element.

This is, Kronos reflects, genuinely interesting.

The only way through the opacity is not through it but around it: shape the conditions in which the boy makes decisions. Create the terrain. Choose the instrument.

KRONOS

(to the lattice, measuring —
the voice of something that
has been patient for ten
thousand years and is done
being patient)

Begin.

He releases the thread. Eighteen months of calculated
silence end in a single moment.

SMASH TO:

THE PERFECT JOSEPH AND GUMBALL: THE MULTIVERSAL SAGA

PART TWO: THE DEVIL YOU DON'T KNOW

ACT ONE: THE SILENCE THAT IS NOT SILENCE

TEXT ON SCREEN: ONE YEAR AFTER THE BATTLE OF ANTARCTICA

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MONITORING ROOM — FORTIETH FLOOR —
DAWN

The monitoring room at dawn. Three walls of screens cycling through dimensional stability indexes, threat assessment feeds, real-time data from seventeen cities across four continents. The air hums with processing. The Moroccan mint tea available at all hours from a standing supply order Tony Stark established and no one has thought to change.

Outside the floor-to-ceiling windows: Manhattan waking. The Hudson catching early light. The skyline existing with the specific indifferent grandeur of something that has been here longer than anything looking at it.

JOSEPH AL-MITHALI stands at the window.

Twenty years old. The year since Antarctica has not aged him in the conventional sense — no new lines, no visible weight. But it has done something more subtle. It has settled something. A quality of permanent attention. The expression of someone who has learned that stopping watching, even once, has a cost.

He has a cup of mint tea. He is thinking four things simultaneously. SEIKO has noted this — he can tell by the specific quality of stillness, the slight forward lean of someone whose body holds position while their mind moves through multiple spaces.

He says, without turning:

JOSEPH
Something is wrong.

YARA GORDON, twenty-one, looks up from her humanitarian response protocols. In fourteen months working beside Joseph Al-Mithali she has learned the precise taxonomy of his declarations. 'Something is wrong' — flat, declarative

— means the observation has already moved past intuition and evidence into the territory of fact.

YARA

What is wrong?

JOSEPH

Nothing. That is what is wrong.

He turns slightly.

JOSEPH

(continuing)

The letter said the second war was coming. Someone writes at that level of specificity and then gives us a year of complete silence — no signatures, no fractures, no movement at any monitored perimeter — only if the silence is intentional. Only if the silence is the plan.

YARA

We've used the year. We're stronger than we were.

JOSEPH

Yes. But we've been preparing for what we know. Someone who thinks in decades has been preparing for what we don't.

The door opens. SEIKO TOAST, twenty, enters with three tablets and the expression of someone who has found something he would genuinely prefer not to have found. He has been at his station since four in the morning.

SEIKO

Energy signatures. Twelve. Globally scattered. Appearing and disappearing in seventy-two-hour cycles. The pattern reads as random on every standard analysis. It took me three days to find it because it was designed to take three days.

JOSEPH

What is it?

SEIKO

A diagnostic sequence. Perimeter
resistance testing from outside.
Someone is walking our fence –
measuring the fracture points without
touching anything hard enough to
trigger our detection threshold.

He pulls up a three-dimensional globe. Twelve points of
light across its surface – London, São Paulo, Mumbai,
Seoul, Lagos, Cairo, Sydney, Toronto, Berlin, Buenos Aires,
Jakarta, Casablanca.

Joseph's eyes stop on the last one.

SEIKO

(continuing)

Seventy-two hours until the diagnostic
sequence completes.

JOSEPH

(quietly – already moving)

Full team. One hour.

Seiko goes. Joseph stands at the window for another minute.
One year of nothing. Something has been building for one
year and has decided it is done building.

He thinks about the letter. HE WILL STRIKE AT WHAT YOU LOVE
BEFORE HE STRIKES AT YOU. He has been thinking about this
sentence as a warning about the future. He is beginning to
understand – with the specific cold clarity of an intuition
becoming information – that this was not about the future.
It was a description of what was already in motion. What
someone started building eighteen months ago.

He picks up his phone. Dials a Casablanca number.

Two rings.

FATIMA

(V.O. – warm, specific, the
warmth of someone for whom
warmth is a considered
practice)

Joseph. You're calling on a Tuesday.
Is everything alright?

JOSEPH

Everything is fine, Yma. I just
wanted to hear your voice.

FATIMA

(V.O.)

You're calling on a Tuesday morning
before eight o'clock to hear my voice.
That means something is not fine.
You can tell me, you know.

JOSEPH

How is the fig tree doing?

FATIMA

(V.O., amused)

The fig tree. You're calling about
the fig tree on a Tuesday morning.

JOSEPH

I'm calling to check on the fig tree.

FATIMA

(V.O.)

It hasn't given figs yet this year.
But I've told it to persist. I believe
it's listening. Some things need to
be told before they will.

Joseph almost smiles.

JOSEPH

Good. I'll call Sunday as usual.

FATIMA

(V.O.)

Are you drinking water? The city

is deceptive. I've said this.

JOSEPH
I'm drinking mint tea.

FATIMA
(V.O.)
That counts. But also water. And
Joseph — whatever it is. You'll find
the way through. You always do.

JOSEPH
(quietly)
I love you.

FATIMA
(V.O.)
I love you. Sunday.

The line closes. Joseph holds the phone for a moment. Then
he goes to the briefing room.

**INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SECURE BRIEFING ROOM — ONE HOUR
LATER**

The assembled team fills the room. BATMAN — present with
the specific stillness of someone for whom stillness is
readiness. IRON MAN — awake thirty-one hours, performing
the function of someone who hasn't been. DOCTOR STRANGE.
SUPERMAN. WONDER WOMAN. THOR. GUMBALL in a chair slightly
too large for him. DARWIN beside him, slightly tilted in
his direction in the unconscious way of someone for whom
proximity to one specific person is a baseline condition.

JOSEPH
The perimeter is being walked. Someone
with dimensional fracture capability
is testing our defenses from outside —
systematically, without engagement.
The diagnostic completes in seventy-two
hours. The question is who and toward
what end.

SEIKO

Profile matches zero catalogued
entities.
But overlaid with temporal-origin
threat
files — entities that manipulate when
rather than where — one profile type
emerges. Not a dimensional traveler.
Something that reaches a location by
changing when the location exists.

DOCTOR STRANGE

Temporal Architects. There are records
in the Sanctum. Old ones. Beings that
don't experience time as a medium they
move through. They experience it as
raw material. They don't go to places
through time. They reshape when the
place is.

BATMAN

Which means our entire defense
architecture
is built on the wrong assumption.

JOSEPH

So we reinforce every identified
fracture
point. Batman — defense architecture
adapted for temporal attack vectors.
Strange — temporal shielding on the
fracture sites. Seiko — predictive
mapping of the diagnostic's focus.

He pauses.

JOSEPH

(quieter — the specific quiet
of something he has been
thinking since the window)
Full surveillance on everyone connected
to me personally. Not operationally.
Personally.

He doesn't explain why. He goes.

SEIKO

(to Yara, quietly – after
he's gone)
He's frightened.

YARA

Yes.

SEIKO

He doesn't usually show it that way.

YARA

(watching the door)
No. That's why this is different.

INT. EPSTEIN'S FACILITY – UNDISCLOSED – SIMULTANEOUS

CROSS-CUT: While Joseph briefs his team – the other half of the equation.

Epstein sits in a room with no identifying features. He is reviewing three reports from three nodes, each painting the same picture: the MPA team is operational but altered. The grief he has planned for has not yet happened – it is eighteen months away still – but the anticipation of his plan's execution has given him a stillness that the reports confirm: everything is proceeding on schedule.

He picks up a phone.

EPSTEIN

(to the contact – precise,
each word doing exactly its
intended work)

Confirm the electromagnetic profile
of the building's 1987 wiring. By
end of week. Precisely, not
approximately. And identify the
shift change window at the surveillance
rotation. I need four minutes minimum.

He listens.

EPSTEIN

(continuing)

No. Not yet. We wait for the diagnostic

to complete. We wait for the city
deployments. We wait for the specific
window that grief opens in operational
discipline. We have been patient for
eighteen months. Three more weeks is
nothing.

He closes the phone. He sits. He thinks about the
conversation he will have with the boy. He has been
composing it in his head for months. He thinks: if you tell
the right person the right truth at the right moment, you
don't need to fight them. You use them to accomplish the
thing you both need accomplished.

He is entirely patient.

He is smiling.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MONITORING ROOM — 11:47 P.M.

Joseph on the edge of his bed in the dark. Not sleeping.
Running the three-day calculation: what begins when the
diagnostic ends. Where they will hit first. In what
sequence.

He is also thinking about the letter. HE WILL STRIKE AT
WHAT YOU LOVE BEFORE HE STRIKES AT YOU. He has been reading
this as a future warning. Tonight, in the dark, with the
calculation running, he has the first clear sense that he
has been reading the sentence wrong. It is not about what
will happen. It is a description of what is already
happening. What someone started eighteen months ago.

The alarms start. RED tier. Simultaneous across the entire
contact network.

Joseph reaches for his phone before the first alert has
finished.

SEIKO

(over phone — stripped to
information)

Cosmic Vault. All containment systems

down. All cell blocks. Simultaneously.
Thirty seconds from first failure to
complete collapse.

JOSEPH

Who's missing?

SEIKO

(V.O. - a precise pause)

Cell Block X. Containment Class Ultra.
Jeffrey Epstein.

Joseph closes his eyes. One. Two. Three. He opens them. He
is already moving.

CUT TO:

ACT TWO: THE VAULT AND THE DEVIL

EXT. COSMIC VAULT — ARCTIC — SIX HOURS AFTER THE BREACH — DAWN

The Cosmic Vault is burning.

Until six hours ago: the most secure facility in any catalogued dimension. Built into granite forty kilometers north of Resolute Bay. Vibranium composite walls. Seventeen independent containment systems. Stark technology layered with Strange's most durable enchantments. The engineers were told that failure was not an acceptable parameter.

The outer wall breached from both sides simultaneously. The interior security grid: dead. The triple-redundant emergency power system destroyed by something that knew exactly where all three nodes were and struck them in the correct sequence — because any other sequence would have triggered the failsafe.

Whoever did this knew the facility better than the people who designed it.

WIDE: Joseph, Yara, Seiko, Batman, Iron Man in the Arctic dawn surveying the damage. Smoke rising in a perfectly vertical column in the windless cold. The specific wrongness of a facility designed for geological permanence that has simply stopped being there.

Nobody speaks.

INT. COSMIC VAULT — OUTER CORRIDOR — CONTINUOUS

The one surviving guard — KOWALSKI, former Delta Force — sits against the wall with his thermal suit burned in patterns consistent with multiple directed-energy weapons deployed simultaneously. He is badly hurt. He is conscious. He is almost calm — the specific calm of someone on the other side of catastrophic experience.

KOWALSKI

(reporting with the precision
of someone who understands
the precision matters)
Interior access codes dropped
simultaneously. All fourteen cell
blocks.
Someone had the actual authentication
keys. Not the override protocol.
The keys themselves. The ones that
change every twelve hours. Someone
knew what they were when they changed.

BATMAN

Inside operative.

KOWALSKI

And outside. Simultaneous. The breach
didn't register as a breach until the
thing was already twenty meters inside
the wall. It came through by existing
at a moment when the wall wasn't there.

He looks directly at Joseph.

KOWALSKI

(delivering this precisely)
Before it left, it said — I'm
repeating this exactly because it
seemed like the kind of thing that
was meant to be repeated exactly —
'Tell the boy the Devil says hello.'

The silence is not surprise. It is confirmation.

SEIKO

(in Joseph's earpiece)
Temporal signature at the breach.
Not dimensional transit — temporal.
The wall wasn't penetrated spatially.
It was penetrated chronologically.
Something moved through it by existing
at a moment when the wall wasn't there.
Kronos. The signature matches.

JOSEPH

(quietly, to Batman)

Then this was planned across time.
Not just across space.

BATMAN

Which means from someone's perspective,
the plan has already succeeded.

Joseph looks at Seiko's tablet. The prisoner manifest. One cell highlighted. Cell Block X. Containment Class Ultra. Gone. Jeffrey Epstein.

He looks at the name for a long time.

CUT TO:

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SECURE BRIEFING ROOM — LATER

The lights dim. The main display fills a wall. Seiko has assembled the file — 847 pages — organized with the precision of someone who believes that information, properly arranged, tells its own story.

The file begins not with a name but with a DIAGRAM: twenty-three nodes in a web with no center. Because someone who understood the vulnerabilities of centralized systems built it without one.

The room is full. Every hero who answered the first call. Sixty people, standing and sitting and leaning, with the specific density of a room where everyone understands that what is being said matters.

SEIKO

The subject is not a story about
one man. He is a story about a system.
A specific type of operational node
that accumulates not power but access
to everyone who has power, and makes
itself necessary to all of them
simultaneously.

He advances to the next display. Twenty-three nodes, now labeled.

SEIKO

(continuing)

The mechanism: identify what every relevant party needs, or fears. Acquire the evidence of what they have done or could be made to appear to have done. Become the custodian of that evidence. Make yourself the infrastructure through which power flows. Never be the power itself – always be the thing that makes power possible.

The room is quiet with the specific quality of a room absorbing something that reframes what it already knew.

YARA

(to herself – recognizing)

The Architecture of Permission.

JOSEPH

What?

YARA

My dissertation. Three years of research.
Not him specifically – the system.
How it operates. What makes it stable.
What its structural vulnerabilities are.

SEIKO

(without drama)

I know. I read it last week. It is the single most analytically useful document in this entire file.

Yara looks at him. The specific expression of someone who has just received the most significant professional affirmation of their career, delivered by someone who doesn't make such affirmations casually.

JOSEPH

(reading from the display)

'Subject's analysis indicates he understands that the Ideal's greatest

vulnerability is not power but
connection — that it can be struck
most effectively by removing the
people who make the Ideal possible,
not by targeting the Ideal directly.'

He reads it again. Very quietly:

JOSEPH
He's not coming for me.

Silence.

JOSEPH
(for the room)
He's coming for the people who
make me possible. My team. My family.
The architecture of what I am.

He stands.

JOSEPH
Full protection protocols on everyone
connected to me personally.
Immediately.
And find Kronos. Not Epstein — Kronos.
Epstein is the instrument. Kronos
is the architect. We understand the
architect first.

He leaves. The room sits with the weight of what has been
said.

CUT TO:

ACT THREE: THE ARCHITECT OF TIME

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — GRAND CONFERENCE HALL — THREE DAYS LATER

Three days of fortification. All of it methodical, professional, and — this is what Joseph lies awake knowing — fundamentally reactive. They are preparing for what they know. The thing coming knows what they know.

The full assembly. Every hero. IRON MAN. SUPERMAN. BATMAN. WONDER WOMAN. THOR. THE HULK. BLACK PANTHER. SPIDER-MAN. DOCTOR STRANGE. HARRY, HERMIONE, RON. GANDALF. THE FLASH. AQUAMAN. WOLVERINE. CAPTAIN AMERICA. JOHN WICK at the back, still. BLADE by the east exit, because Blade always knows where the exits are. Sixty people. The room was designed for forty.

Joseph at the front. Four hours of sleep. Immaculately prepared anyway.

JOSEPH

The Vault breach was coordinated between an internal operative and an external temporal entity we're designating Kronos. Epstein's release was not the goal — it was the announcement. A statement delivered at a scale we couldn't ignore.

BATMAN

(pulling up five-city threat data)

Significant dimensional stress in five major population centers. New York, London, Tokyo, Paris, Sydney. Imminent fracture events within seventy-two hours.

JOSEPH

Distraction architecture. Five cities simultaneously splits our forces while the actual operation runs where we're not looking. The cities are real —

they require response. But they're
not the strategic center. We respond.
And we watch what we're not being
shown.

Every screen in the room goes BLACK simultaneously.

Not a failure. A replacement. Something has taken control
of the display architecture with the ease of someone
walking through a door they have had a key to for years.
The transition is instantaneous.

Then: a VOICE.

Not through the speakers. Through the air itself, converted
without announcement into a conducting medium for something
it was not designed to carry. The voice occupies every
frequency simultaneously. It arrives at every point in the
room from every direction. It is old – not the old of age,
but the old of geological processes, of things that operate
on timescales longer than anything in the room.

KRONOS
(from the air itself –
measured, without drama)
Because I am here.

In the center of the room – not at the door, not at any
secured entry point – a CRACK appears.

Not in space. In time.

Approximately three meters tall. Shining in colors that
exist in no part of the human visual spectrum and yet are
perceived by everyone: not light, but the visual
representation of information. The colors of moments that
have already happened layered over moments that have not
happened yet, cycling between them with the rhythm of
something alive. The crack pulses with a frequency felt in
the chest, in the teeth, in very old bones.

Through it: KRONOS. Seven feet. The compressed density of
something that has contained enormous power for a very long
time. A cloak that is not cloth – the fabric of witnessed
events, inscribed with the record of ten thousand years of
observation, moving with the motion of information rather
than wind. Eyes: gold, without pupil or iris, the eyes of
something that records rather than perceives.

He carries a STAFF of crystallized temporal matter – a physical moment frozen at the point of maximum force, casting shadows that correspond to a different time than the room's light.

KRONOS

(the deliberate pacing of
someone who has all the time
that exists)

I am Kronos. The Architect of Temporal
Systems. The Curator of what was and
what will be. I have been building
toward this moment for ten thousand
years. And soon: the master of all
that is.

Time STOPS.

Not metaphorically. Time stops.

SUPERMAN: right foot two inches above the floor. BATMAN:
hand halfway to his belt. THOR: Mjolnir rotating at forty-
seven degrees, arrested. TONY: visor frozen half-open, mid-
sentence. WONDER WOMAN: caught at the inception of a
movement toward her bracers. THE HULK: leaning forward,
hands on the table. Sixty people, frozen in the
configuration of the moment before action.

Everything and everyone. Stopped.

Except Joseph.

Kronos looks at him. For the first time in approximately
ten thousand years, something enters his expression that is
not quite surprise – more the specific recalibration of a
predictive model returning an unexpected result.

KRONOS

(to Joseph – almost
conversational)

The cosmic energy you carry makes
you immune to basic temporal
suspension.

I had not fully accounted for this.

Joseph crosses the room. Fast. Efficient. No performance.

Kronos raises one hand. Joseph's movement slows — not stopped, but reduced to a fraction, every step costing ten times what it should, moving through a medium with the density of stone and the texture of air.

KRONOS

(almost — almost — with
something adjacent to
respect)

You are strong. But strength operating
in my medium refracts. My medium
has no ceiling. There is no version
of strength that exceeds what time
can do to it.

He reverses Joseph's movement — gently, like rewinding
footage. Joseph returns to his starting position. Kronos
releases the room.

Sixty people stumbling back into motion. Collective
vertigo. Weapons raised. Stances taken.

Kronos does not move. He does not need to.

KRONOS

I've come with an offer. Surrender —
willingly, with dignity — and I will
be merciful. I am not, at my core,
a destroyer. I am an architect.
I prefer to build.

JOSEPH

We will resist.

KRONOS

(without surprise — checking
a box)

I expected exactly that.

He raises his staff. Time portals open at twelve points
around the room's perimeter, each releasing TEMPORAL COPIES
of THANOS, DARKSEID, and VOLDEMORT — variants from
different points in their timelines, each carrying
knowledge of what they did in their original moment and the

bitter adaptation of someone who has been pulled forward to fight enemies they recognize and who have adjusted.

KRONOS

(stepping back toward his
portal)

My army cannot be depleted. Every moment of its defeat creates another available copy. Think of it as a river. You cannot stop a river by removing water. The river is not the water. It is the direction.

He steps back through. The portal closes. The copies
ATTACK.

CHAOS. The close-quarters confusion of fighting enemies who know what you did last time and have adjusted. Sixty people in combat plus forty-seven temporal copies.

JOSEPH

(to Batman, over the chaos)
We can't fight them here. We need
the five cities and we need to think.

BATMAN

Agreed. Tactical withdrawal. The city
responses were always coming.

Joseph takes out his phone. He calls Casablanca. It rings. Voicemail. He tries again. Voicemail. Something cold and ancient moves through him. Not panic – something quieter and more terrible than panic.

CUT TO:

ACT FOUR: THE FIRE THAT REMEMBERS

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MONITORING ROOM — 4:02 A.M.

The alert comes at 4:02 a.m. Not from dimensional sensors. From the Moroccan civil emergency response network — flagged automatically by a subroutine Seiko wrote in his third month at the MPA. He wrote it because Joseph mentioned once that his mother worked in Casablanca, and Seiko decided that any alert from that city should reach him immediately, without delay, regardless of its classification. He has never told Joseph he built this.

Seiko reads the alert. Twice. He looks at the screen for four seconds — not uncertainty, but preparation. He calls Joseph on the override pattern. Fourteen months at the MPA. He has never used it before.

Joseph answers before it finishes ringing.

SEIKO

(V.O. — precisely controlled,
the voice of someone who has
chosen precision over emotion
because this is what the
moment requires)

There's been a fire. Residential
building. Casablanca. Maarif district.

A pause. Very brief. Very precise.

SEIKO

(V.O.)

Rue des Orangers.

Joseph is already out the door.

EXT. CASABLANCA — RUE DES ORANGERS — DAWN

The building on Rue des Orangers.

The south wall, where the jasmine has grown for thirty years — the jasmine his mother photographed in different

stages of bloom over three decades, the jasmine whose scent reached the kitchen window every spring – is damaged. The fourth floor is exposed. Emergency vehicles. The organized professional chaos of people doing their specific jobs in the aftermath of something that cannot be undone.

Joseph arrives. Gets out of the car. Stands on the street and looks at the building.

We do not see his face here. We see the building. The damaged fourth floor. The jasmine below the damage – largely intact, because jasmine is persistent, because the things his mother loved do not simply stop – still reaching up the south wall with the same unhurried determination it has always had.

He goes inside.

INT. IBN RUSHD HOSPITAL – QUIET CORRIDOR – MORNING

The attending physician finds him in the waiting area. Leads him to a quiet corridor – the specific corridor hospitals designate for this specific kind of news. He tells him in Arabic. Clearly. Directly.

CLOSE ON: Joseph's face as he listens.

He is absolutely still. Not the stillness of shock – the stillness of someone whose entire understanding of the structure of things is being rearranged at its foundation, and who has the discipline – accumulated through twenty years and fourteen months of impossible things – to stand in the rearrangement without collapsing.

JOSEPH

(in Arabic)

Shukran lik.

Thank you for telling me.

He stands in the corridor for a very long time. Just standing. Just being the person standing in the space where Fatima Al-Mithali walked for twenty years.

A NURSE passes – older, gray-haired. She slows when she sees him. Not because of who he is – because she worked beside Fatima Al-Mithali for eleven years and she can see

it in his face. She puts her hand on his arm. Two seconds. She says nothing. She goes.

This is the most comfort the world is capable of offering right now. He knows this. He receives it exactly as it is given.

INT. IBN RUSHD HOSPITAL — CORRIDOR — 40 MINUTES LATER

NADIA AL-MITHALI, fifteen, arrives in the state of someone who has received devastating information and has not yet found the way from receiving it to integrating it. The moment between hearing and knowing.

Joseph holds her. Without saying anything. There is nothing to say that would not make itself into something smaller than what this is.

She cries into his shoulder. He does not.

He holds her and he does not. The corridor continues around them. Life, indifferent, continuing.

— INTERLUDE: THE LAST SUNDAY CALL —

**THREE WEEKS BEFORE THE FIRE. SUNDAY, 10:07 A.M. CASABLANCA
TIME**

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MONITORING ROOM — (FLASHBACK)

Joseph steps out of the threat assessment review and dials. She picks up on the second ring. The call lasts forty-one minutes.

She asks about his health first. Not as a formality — as a specific inquiry. The way a clinician asks.

JOSEPH

I'm fine.

FATIMA

(V.O. – gently firm)

Fine is not an answer, habibi. Fine is a direction. Be more specific.

JOSEPH

Three cracked ribs that have healed. Residual fatigue from dimensional frequency exposure. A persistent headache I'm attributing to screen time.

FATIMA

(V.O.)

It's always the screen time. And drink water.

They talk about NADIA's engineering coursework. They talk about the fig tree – three actual figs this year. Photographed and sent with the subject line 'it persisted.' They talk about HASSAN's Saturday program – forty-one students in the second cohort, a waiting list developing.

Near the end:

FATIMA

(V.O.)

You sound tired in a specific way. Not the physical tired. The other kind.

JOSEPH

I'm thinking about something I can't resolve yet.

FATIMA

(V.O.)

Leave it alone tonight. Some things need to be left alone before they become solvable. Sleep is the mind doing work you cannot consciously supervise.

JOSEPH

I know.

FATIMA

(V.O.)

I know you know. I'm saying it anyway.
Knowing it and doing it are different
things, and you treat them as the same.

He laughs. She laughs.

At the very end – in the register she uses for this
specific thing, which she uses every call:

FATIMA

(V.O.)

I'm proud of you. I say this every
call and mean it every call
differently.
Because you keep giving me new reasons.
Today's reason is that you remembered
to drink the water.

JOSEPH

I didn't actually drink the water.

FATIMA

(V.O. – warm)

I know. But you thought about it.
Which is progress. Sunday.

JOSEPH

Sunday. I love you.

FATIMA

(V.O.)

I love you.

The connection closes at 10:48 a.m. He goes back to the
threat assessment.

He does not know it is the last call. He will think about
this for a long time afterward. He will think: I would not
have done anything differently. Every call was complete.
She made sure of that – deliberately, with the
intentionality of someone who understands that last times
are possible and has decided to treat every time
accordingly.

The recurring things are the real things. The Sunday calls. The fig tree photographs. The instruction to drink more water than you think you need. These were not context. These were the thing itself.

END FLASHBACK.

CUT TO:

INT. AL-MITHALI APARTMENT — FATIMA'S KITCHEN — DAY FOUR

The fourth day.

The plants on the window ledge are still alive. The ficus she maintained for eleven years. The two smaller succulents. The pot of herbs. They need water. He waters them. Each one. Carefully. The way she showed him. His hand goes to the right place for the watering can without thinking, because he has watched her put it there a hundred times.

Her Quran on the bookshelf. Her handwriting in the margins — notes about specific verses, the dates she wrote them, her precise careful hand.

A photograph he has not seen before: his parents' wedding. HASSAN young, laughing at something outside the frame. FATIMA in white, looking directly at the camera with the expression she always had when she knew she was being documented — composed, complete, not performing anything.

He sits at the kitchen table.

SEIKO calls.

SEIKO

(V.O. — with the precision of
someone who has been
composing this call for
hours)

The electrical fault was real. It was
also induced. A precise electromagnetic

pulse introduced through the building's
1987 wiring. The seven-minute
surveillance
window was engineered. The pattern
matches Epstein's operational signature
in four separate analytical frameworks.

JOSEPH

(flat)

But we can't prove it. Legally.
Formally.

SEIKO

(V.O.)

Not yet. The method is clean.
He understood our evidentiary
requirements before he built it.

A long pause.

SEIKO

(V.O. — carefully, a
different register)

Joseph.

JOSEPH

I'm here.

SEIKO

(V.O.)

I don't have the right words.
I don't know the right thing.

JOSEPH

(quietly — meaning it
completely)

You called. That's the right thing.

He waters the last plant. He sets the watering can in
exactly the place she kept it. Then he calls Nadia's
school, his father's sister, the hospital. He does the
specific, irreplaceable work of someone organizing what
needs to be organized when someone irreplaceable is gone.
He does it completely. He leaves nothing undone.

Then he calls the team together and briefs them. Organized. Specific. He does not cry.

Afterward:

EXT. AL-MITHALI APARTMENT — ROOFTOP — EVENING

YARA finds him on the roof. She stands beside him without saying anything for a long time — very good at this, at presence without pressure.

The Casablanca skyline. The Atlantic beyond. The last light on the water.

JOSEPH

(without looking away from
the water)

She called every Sunday without fail.
I had a routing protocol — Seiko
built it — that made the call come
through regardless of what dimension
I was in. Because I knew if I missed
one she would worry.

A pause.

JOSEPH

I kept every one.

YARA

(gently)

That's love. Not deception.

JOSEPH

It didn't protect her.

Yara is quiet. She does not offer a corrective.

JOSEPH

(after a while)

I want to make sure — when I go after
him, and I will — I'm doing it for
the right reasons. Not for this.
Not for what I feel right now.

He looks at the Atlantic.

JOSEPH

She told me: don't let the world make
you hard, Joseph. Hard things shatter.
Soft things bend and come back.
Be water.

YARA

(quietly)
Be water.

JOSEPH

I'm trying to understand the difference
between being water and being still.

YARA

You're here. Watering her plants.
Sitting with her things. Organizing
what needs organizing. That's not
stillness. That's water finding the
shape of what it has to move through.

The light is going.

JOSEPH

Will you stay? Tonight. I don't want
to be here alone.

YARA

(without hesitation)
Of course.

They stand on the roof. The city below. The ocean beyond.
The jasmine from the south wall reaching them even up here
— persistent, still itself.

CUT TO:

ACT FIVE: FIVE FRONTS

TEXT ON SCREEN: THREE DAYS AFTER THE FIRE — JOSEPH HAS
RETURNED

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — COMMAND CENTER — DAY

Joseph at his station. Something has changed in him — not the hardness he was warned against. A clarity. The kind that comes when something you loved has been taken and the grief has burned through the noise and left only the essential.

He is organized. He is specific. He is precisely who he is. What he is has not been diminished by what has happened — it has been clarified.

SEIKO

(to the room)

Five-city deployment active. Temporal copies in all five locations. New York, London, Tokyo, Paris, Sydney. Total enemy count: approximately fourteen thousand across all theaters.

BATMAN

Team assignments. Iron Man — air coordination across all five. Strange — temporal containment. The copies can't be killed, only held. Seiko — run all five feeds simultaneously.

SEIKO

I'll need six data streams and forty-seven screens.

BATMAN

(without pause)

You'll have them.

SEIKO

I'll also need water and food every
three hours.

BATMAN

Darwin.

DARWIN

Already planned for.

FIVE SCREENS — SPLIT FRAME

SIMULTANEOUS BATTLE FEEDS — ZIMMER'S SCORE BENEATH ALL FIVE

NEW YORK — EMPIRE STATE BUILDING — ROOFTOP — NIGHT

JOSEPH, SUPERMAN, and WONDER WOMAN against a temporal THANOS — the complete Gauntlet, drawn from an earlier moment in that timeline before any of the battles that cracked it. He knows what they will try. He has already adjusted.

The fight is three-dimensional above the 102nd floor. Wind a factor. Altitude making certain physics irrelevant and others acute. Thanos deploys the Stones systematically: Space to redirect attacks before arrival, Reality to alter what is real, Time to slow responses in fractions that compound.

Joseph takes a direct hit from the Power Stone that sends him twenty meters across the rooftop into the parapet. He gets up. Not dramatically. Not with announcement. Simply — because getting up is what you do, because the only alternative is not on the list of available options.

He squares. He goes.

THE HULK arrives from below — seven hundred meters of direct vertical ascent, landing behind Thanos with the force of a small geological event. The combined assault of four — cosmic energy disrupting the Stones' quantum

coherence, Asgardian power, three-thousand-year precision,
geological impact – shatters the gauntlet.

SEIKO

(in their earpieces)

New York. Gauntlet's down. One city.

LONDON – TOWER BRIDGE – SIMULTANEOUS

The Thames at night. HARRY against VOLDEMORT on Tower Bridge. Below the bridge: DARWIN with three civilians – a family who refused to evacuate. He sits with them on cold stone. Talks quietly about things that are not the battle. He holds the child's hand – six years old, asking what the lights are. He tells her: the good people winning.

VOLDEMORT

(over the Thames)

You've been afraid of me your entire
life, Potter. You will always be.
I am what you cannot stop fearing.

HARRY

(steady)

I was afraid of you. That's true.
I was also afraid you'd be right
about me. You weren't. That's the
difference between us – you've never
been afraid of being wrong.

The PATRONUS – enormous, brilliant – backed by Hermione's magic and Gandalf's ancient tradition, overwhelms decades of dark practice. The wand shatters. Ash disperses east over the Thames.

SEIKO

(V.O.)

London cleared. Two cities.

TOKYO – REACTOR CORE – SIMULTANEOUS

IRON MAN and CYBORG. Two technological intelligences interfacing faster than language. The strike point has a twelve-millisecond window. They hit it in eight.

SEIKO
(V.O.)
Tokyo. Three cities.

PARIS — THE IRON CITY — SIMULTANEOUS

Thor in the City of Light. Also a city of iron and steel infrastructure — the Eiffel Tower, the bridges, the metro, the Haussmann building frames — that becomes, in the hands of a god of lightning, a weapon of extraordinary scope.

WOLVERINE
(watching)
When you show up, you show up.

THOR
(genuinely, exuberantly
pleased)
I am in my element.

WOLVERINE
Your element is 'entire iron city.'

THOR
Today it is.

SEIKO
(V.O.)
Paris. Four cities.

SYDNEY — THE FINAL CALCULATION — SIMULTANEOUS

DARKSEID requires extraordinary response. CAPTAIN AMERICA. BLACK WIDOW. AQUAMAN. And — through a temporal corridor Strange extracts from three hours in the future — a SECOND-TIMELINE THOR, available because his timeline is currently in the post-Paris phase and this intervention takes twelve minutes he considers well spent. Nobody asks further questions.

All five battles end within forty minutes of each other. Across fourteen hours of five-front warfare, Seiko has managed every data stream and called every critical moment. His right shoulder is badly damaged. He has not acknowledged this.

Darwin hands him water. Seiko drinks without taking his eyes off the screens.

SEIKO

(into the comm)

All five cities cleared. Seven significantly wounded, three critically. Temporal copies contained. Reconstitute in eighteen hours.

KRONOS

(his voice filling every comm channel simultaneously)

Come to the final battle. Come to the ocean. I am ready. I have always been ready.

BATMAN

(immediately)

We do not go to the ocean.

INT. MPA MOBILE COMMAND — AIRBORNE — ATLANTIC — NIGHT

The aircraft. The full team consolidating. The exhaustion of people who have fought five simultaneous battles and are about to fight a sixth. This is always the cost of the thing.

BATMAN

The open ocean is his terrain. Maximum freedom of movement. No infrastructure for us to leverage. His army emerges from the portal directly behind him — we'd always be fighting toward his supply line. The current position is a trap designed to look like a battlefield.

JOSEPH

So we don't go to the trap. We build the terrain.

SEIKO

(already running analysis)
Mount Kilimanjaro. A secondary
dimensional nexus — the fracture lines
from Kronos's network converge there.
He can't ignore it if we begin sealing
those fractures from that position.
He has to come to us.

JOSEPH

He comes personally. The Kilimanjaro
fractures are load-bearing in his
temporal architecture. If they fall,
the architecture falls. He can't send
proxies for this.

BATMAN

Yes.

JOSEPH

Good.

He turns to the window. The ocean below. He is thinking
about something he has not told anyone. Something DOCTOR
STRANGE gave him three weeks ago at seven in the morning
with instructions not to share.

— FLASHBACK: DR. STRANGE'S OFFICE — THREE WEEKS AGO —

INT. DOCTOR STRANGE'S OFFICE — EARLY MORNING (FLASHBACK)

Strange's office. The specific organization of someone who
understands that physical arrangement and internal clarity
are related.

Strange places something on Joseph's desk: a small
crystalline object, approximately the size of a golf ball,
glowing with a light that seems to come from a different
time than the room.

DOCTOR STRANGE

I found this eight months ago at a fracture intersection. I've been carrying it since. I've told no one. Because Kronos monitors every channel we use — and this information loses all its value the moment he knows it exists.

JOSEPH

What is it?

DOCTOR STRANGE

A Frozen Time Fragment. Extra-dimensional crystal containing a moment of pure temporal stasis. At Kronos's full power, useless — he absorbs it. At forty percent capacity — which is what he'll be at after a prolonged engagement — it removes his temporal abilities entirely. For sixty seconds of normal time.

JOSEPH

Sixty seconds.

DOCTOR STRANGE

Against Kronos without temporal abilities: everything. Sixty seconds is the margin we've never had.

JOSEPH

Why not use it yourself?

DOCTOR STRANGE

I'm the obvious choice. The obvious choice is the watched choice. He has a model of me. He doesn't have a complete model of you. You do things that can't be predicted from your file — you make decisions that emerge from how you see the people around you, in ways his predictive models

can't fully simulate. You're the one
person in this system who is genuinely
opaque to him.

Joseph picks up the Fragment. Warm — not from temperature.
From the residue of the moment it contains.

JOSEPH

Thank you. For carrying this for
eight months.

DOCTOR STRANGE

(simply)

Don't thank me yet. Make it work.

END FLASHBACK.

CUT TO:

ACT SIX: THE MOUNTAIN WE CHOOSE

EXT. MOUNT KILIMANJARO — SUMMIT APPROACH — DAWN

5,895 meters. The cold of high altitude mixing with equatorial warmth — a combination that makes no ordinary atmospheric sense and is therefore exact and real and strange. The sky the particular blue of altitude: deeper, denser, less filtered than sea-level air.

WIDE: The African continent spread in every direction below. The clouds beneath their feet. The sky above enormous and clean.

The heroes position across the mountain. BATMAN's tactical grid — built in six hours of analysis during the flight — has turned the mountain's geology into a defensive architecture. Each elevation a position. Each rock face cover. The approach routes funneled through terrain that advantages the defenders.

GUMBALL positions at the mid-slope with abandoned climbing equipment he identified on the approach as useful and has not explained to anyone how he intends to use.

DARWIN positions behind him. Slightly.

DARWIN
(already knowing)
I'm supposed to cover the south approach.

GUMBALL
The rock formation covers the south approach. I checked.

DARWIN
There's no rock formation on the south that —

GUMBALL
Darwin.

DARWIN

Yes.

GUMBALL

Thank you for always being behind me.

Darwin is quiet for a moment.

DARWIN

That's my preferred position.

The battle begins at dawn. It lasts eleven hours.

EXT. MOUNT KILIMANJARO — BATTLE — THROUGHOUT THE DAY

The mountain does not accommodate what is happening on it. The wind is constant. The altitude is absolute. The cold is real. These are not metaphors — they are the physical conditions of a battle fought at 5,895 meters above sea level.

DOCTOR STRANGE works along the mountain's dimensional fault lines, sealing fracture points in Kronos's temporal architecture one by one — each one requiring sustained magical effort, each one sealed removing another of Kronos's supply routes. He works with the systematic patience of someone whose objective is not the battle but the architecture underneath it.

THOR in the high-altitude winds, where the electrical conditions are amplified by the thinness of the air and the conductivity of volcanic rock, fights with the specific exhilaration of someone made for exactly these conditions.

GUMBALL does not fight the way larger entities fight. He fights the way Gumball fights — with the improvisational intelligence of someone who has spent his entire life being the smallest person in the room and has developed, through necessity, the ability to find the solution nobody else is looking for because nobody else needed to look there. BATMAN will spend thirty minutes analyzing his use of the climbing equipment afterward and describe it as 'completely unintuitive and entirely correct.'

Seven heroes significantly wounded through the day.

SEIKO at the protected observation point, running tactical analysis without stopping. His right shoulder is now badly damaged. He manages it through the complete direction of his attention toward his screens.

EXT. MOUNT KILIMANJARO — KRONOS'S POSITION — LATE AFTERNOON

Kronos arrives two hours in. Takes a position on a platform of crystallized time at the summit's eastern edge with the deliberateness of someone who has chosen this location precisely and is done moving.

He directs his armies with ten thousand years of practiced patience. His temporal awareness covers the entire mountain simultaneously — he sees every attack before it arrives, adjusts for every tactical change before it is made.

He is watching everything.

He is not watching the quiet approach.

EXT. MOUNT KILIMANJARO — JOSEPH'S APPROACH — SAME TIME

Joseph moves through nothing.

Not through the battle — through the gaps. The specific path that exists when everyone is watching the loud things. No dramatic approach. No announcement. The specific invisibility of someone who is not doing the expected thing, moving at the pace and angle that does not register as motion worth noting.

The Frozen Time Fragment in his jacket pocket. Warm. Adjacent to time.

He moves across rock face. Through cover. Along the terrain Batman mapped. He is thinking about his mother's hands pressing flat on the kitchen table when she read her Quran. The same gesture his father made. The same gesture he made on the console when the heroes arrived in Central Park.

Be water.

The quiet thing. The thing nobody is watching.

He reaches Kronos's platform from below — from the direction Kronos is not watching, because the battle is in

every other direction, because the battle is the loud thing, and Joseph has learned that the loud thing is almost never the real thing.

He places the Frozen Time Fragment against the staff.

SIXTY SECONDS.

EXT. MOUNT KILIMANJARO — SIXTY SECONDS — REAL TIME

In sixty seconds of normal time, against Kronos at forty percent capacity, stripped of temporal manipulation:

SUPERMAN at his actual speed — not the speed Kronos's temporal manipulation reduces to manageable, but his actual speed, which no one without temporal ability can fully track.

THOR with his actual force — not the force Kronos temporal-deflects in fractions before it lands, but all of it, every ounce of Asgardian physics applied without mediation.

WONDER WOMAN with three thousand years of trained precision — moving into positions that Kronos's tactical mind cannot process fast enough without the temporal advantage that gives him the time to process them.

Together: they accomplish what decades of direct conflict at full power would not have achieved.

When the Fragment expires — sixty seconds exactly, the crystal going dark — Kronos is contained in a TEMPORAL LOCK that Strange and Harry maintain together. The lock holds him outside normal time. Suspended in a moment. Unable to act.

The temporal armies dissolve. Without their source, without the will that moves them, they simply stop being there.

The Battle of Kilimanjaro ends at 6:47 a.m. the following morning. Eleven hours and forty minutes. In cold air and the constant equatorial wind.

WIDE: The heroes on the mountain. The African sky
lightening. Below, the continent in the first light.

They won.

But Epstein is still operational. And Epstein does not need
to fight.

CUT TO:

ACT SEVEN: THE WINDOW GRIEF OPENS

EXT. SWISS ALPS — DAY — FOUR DAYS AFTER KILIMANJARO

A Category Three dimensional fracture in the Swiss Alps.
Genuine signature. Real crisis requiring real response.

This is the first thing about the ambush: it is built on a genuine crisis. Epstein understands that fake crises can be detected. Real ones cannot. You can only respond to them.

They go.

The AMBUSH comes from four directions simultaneously.

THE RED FRACTURE UNIT — assembled over months by someone who studied everything about how this team moves. Their formations. Their tactical habits. Individual response patterns. Who covers whom instinctively. And specifically: how the team moves when grief has been introduced into the system, which is different from how it moves at rest.

Standard assault doctrine covers three simultaneous vectors. The response to three is drilled — embodied, automatic. Four is outside the trained response set. Four requires figuring it out in real time, under fire, in a moment when operational sharpness has been reduced by the weight of what has been carried.

Epstein had spent months selecting this window. He was not wrong.

Seven heroes wounded significantly. Three critically. VISION requires four months to recover. The extraction succeeds only because Joseph deliberately steps into direct fire from three attack vectors, drawing all of them while the others reach the evacuation point.

He is hit three times in thirty seconds. He gets up three times in thirty seconds.

More critically: YARA and GUMBALL are missing. Taken. Leverage. A statement. Epstein communicating at a level that doesn't require words.

Seiko finds the trace six hours later: a controlled fracture, four seconds, at the exact moment the last hero went through the evacuation point. Two people pulled through by name. Not by accident.

INT. MPA MEDICAL WING — HALLWAY — EVENING

Joseph sits in a chair. His wrist is wrapped. He looks at the wall.

Batman sits across from him.

Six minutes of silence. Batman has learned when silence is the right choice.

BATMAN

The grief is real. I'm not asking you to set it aside. But you know why he took them.

JOSEPH

Leverage.

BATMAN

Yes. He needs them alive for the demonstration. We have time.

JOSEPH

Everything he does is a statement. The network, the leverage, the taking — all communication. He wants me to understand what he can do and what I can't stop.

BATMAN

Then we respond. Through action.

Joseph looks at the wall. He thinks about Yara saying of course — without hesitation. He thinks about Gumball putting a chipped mug in his pocket before stepping through the dimensional crack in his living room.

JOSEPH

(standing)

We be smarter. And we be done being
caught the same way twice.

He goes to the assembled heroes.

JOSEPH

(to the room)

We were beaten today. He planned
better than us and used what we gave
him. That is real and it is finished.
He doesn't get the same window twice.

He looks at Seiko. At a workstation. Working. A bandage
above his left eye. His right shoulder visibly wrong. Not
stopping.

Something tightens in Joseph's chest. He files it. He will
come back.

JOSEPH

(to the room)

We find Yara and Gumball. We find
Epstein. In that order.

The dimensional fracture opens beneath them all. Targeted.
Controlled. Specific. The floor is not there. All of them
fall. Prime Earth shakes. Goes silent.

SMASH TO:

ACT EIGHT: THE CONFRONTATION

TEXT ON SCREEN: THREE WEEKS AFTER THE AMBUSH

INT. EPSTEIN'S PRIMARY NODE — NIGHT

The facility exists inside a dimensional frequency that standard MPA scanning cannot identify — because Epstein spent six months before his arrest ensuring it wouldn't appear in any detection catalogue, through small, untraceable adjustments made via a contact inside the relevant department.

It looks like a financial services office. Clean lines. Expensive materials. The aesthetic of institutional wealth refined enough to look like restraint.

JEFFREY EPSTEIN sits behind a desk with nothing on it.

Joseph enters alone. He found the location through eleven days of analysis — working backward from the network's decision-making architecture rather than forward from the man. If you understand the architect, you can predict where the architect will stand.

Epstein looks up. His expression does not change. But something in his posture recalibrates — the micro-adjustment of a predictive model receiving a result.

The result matches the prediction. He seems, if anything, satisfied.

EPSTEIN
(without preamble)
You found me in eleven days.
I estimated twelve.

JOSEPH
(standing — not approaching)
You wanted to be found.

EPSTEIN

Yes.

JOSEPH

Why.

EPSTEIN

Because I need you to understand something. And the most efficient delivery of understanding is direct.

He folds his hands on the clear desk.

EPSTEIN

(measured, precise — the voice of someone stating facts)

Power is not what you have. Power is what others believe you might do. What they believe you hold over them. I'm not in this room because I can harm you. I'm here because every significant actor in seventeen dimensions believes I can harm them. The belief is the infrastructure. The infrastructure is the power.

JOSEPH

Is that why you do this? Power?

EPSTEIN

(something being considered)

I do this because I'm very good at it. Power is a description, not the motivation. The motivation is the system. I build systems. I find the structure of how things connect more interesting than the things themselves.

JOSEPH

And my mother. Was she a system?

The specific weight of the question in the specific room.

Epstein looks at him. Not away. At him. He does not avoid this.

EPSTEIN

She was a load-bearing element in
a structure I needed to modify.
I understand that's not how you
experience it.

JOSEPH

(very quietly)

No. It's not.

A long pause. The room. The clear desk. The expensive
artworks. The specific quality of silence in places where
powerful people make decisions that affect people who will
never see the room.

EPSTEIN

I didn't come here to apologize.
I'm telling you this clearly so you
understand who you're dealing with.
I don't experience guilt. I experience
analysis. What I did had a strategic
purpose. The purpose was achieved.
I would do it again.

JOSEPH

(steady — he has thought
about this moment for weeks)

I know. That's why I'm not here
for an apology. I'm here because
you told me to come. So tell me
what you needed me to understand.

EPSTEIN

(leaning slightly forward)

You cannot stop the network by
stopping me. I am the principle
around which the network organized
itself. The network's stability
depends on one physical element:
the center crystal. The node that
maintains the coherence of the entire
system. Destroy nodes alone and they
reconstitute. Destroy the center
crystal and the architecture collapses
permanently. Everything in it becomes

public. Every file. Every account.
Every piece of leverage. All of it.
Gone.

JOSEPH

Why are you telling me this?

EPSTEIN

(the specific quiet of
someone measuring how much
truth to share)

Because Kronos needs my network intact
for his second phase. His temporal
restructuring requires the leverage
architecture as operational
infrastructure.
If you destroy the network –
permanently,
through the center crystal – his second
phase becomes impossible.

JOSEPH

So you're choosing yourself over him.

EPSTEIN

I'm choosing the version of events
in which I continue to exist as
something other than a discarded
instrument. Kronos's plan ends with
him as master of all that is. In
that version, I'm a tool that was
used and is no longer needed.

A pause.

EPSTEIN

(with the specific flatness
of someone stating an
absolute principle)

I have never been a tool. I have
never been discarded. These are not
things that are going to start now.

JOSEPH

The center crystal. Where?

EPSTEIN

The map is in the accounts. Ghislaine
has the key. She knows you'll find her.

He stands. The meeting, from his perspective, is complete.

EPSTEIN

(at the door — turning back)

The people you're looking for.
The young woman and the blue creature.
They're alive. They found their own
way out. She already has. I thought
you should know.

He leaves.

Joseph stands in the empty office.

He thinks: he told me the truth. Every word. And in telling
me the truth he did exactly what he always does — he made
himself necessary. Made himself the key to the next step.
Made himself something that has to be taken seriously even
after what he did.

That is the architecture. Brilliant. Despicable. And the
thing he has to dismantle.

He takes out his phone.

JOSEPH

Seiko. Ghislaine Maxwell. Current
location. Everything you have.

He walks out. The facility empties behind him. Epstein is
already gone. He planned to have this conversation and
planned to leave before any extraction team could reach
position. Joseph knew this. He came anyway. The information
was worth it.

Be water.

CUT TO:

ACT NINE: THE DESERT DREAM

INT./EXT. THE IN-BETWEEN VOID — TIMELESS

They fall through nothing. Then land on something — a surface that has no substance but refuses to let them fall further. The paradox of the in-between: a floor that is not a floor, holding them with the gravity of something that has decided to hold them.

THE VOID SPACE. A sky that is the color of light before it becomes any color — pure potential, casting no shadows, making no distinction between near and far. A silence that is not the absence of sound but the absence of a medium for sound to travel through.

Joseph: standing, counting. Seiko. Batman. Superman. Wonder Woman. Iron Man. Thor. The Hulk. Seven. All alive.

They walk. After two hours, the void ends and a DESERT begins. Not gradually — one step in void-light, the next on red sand. Warm. Specific. Real.

Joseph stands at the boundary. Something clarifies in him — the specific clarity of someone standing at a threshold they recognize. This was always here. They were always going to reach it.

WEEZY GOLD.

He does not know what it is. He has the certainty — precise, informational — that the dream he had weeks ago, written down immediately, told to no one, contains real coordinates.

JOSEPH

We need to find something.

SEIKO

(simply)

What do we do?

JOSEPH

We walk.

- THE DREAM -

INT. JOSEPH'S ROOM - WEEKS AGO (FLASHBACK)

Joseph asleep. The dream has the texture of information,
not imagination.

He stands in a desert - vast, white-gold, warm. Something
moves in the sky with the quality of intention.

THE VOICE

(from everywhere)

The weapon is in the gold.

The gold is in the name.

The name is Weezy.

Joseph wakes. 4:17 a.m. He writes:

1. Epstein is still operational.
2. The final confrontation will require a weapon that does not yet exist.
3. WEEZY GOLD is the key.

He tells no one.

END FLASHBACK.

EXT. THE IN-BETWEEN DESERT - DAY FOUR

The BLACK PEARL appears on the horizon. No water - the ship exists over red sand, its sails filled with a wind that has no meteorological source, there with the confidence of something that belongs wherever it decides it belongs.

On the quarterdeck railing: CAPTAIN JACK SPARROW.

JACK SPARROW
(gesturing broadly)
I was wondering when you lot would
turn up. The in-between tends to
deliver people here eventually.
You have purpose – I can always tell.
People with purpose walk differently.

JOSEPH
We're looking for something called
the Weezy Gold.

Something shifts in Sparrow's expression. Recognition.

JACK SPARROW
(more present)
Then you want the Watcher's Palace.
Come aboard.

INT. THE BLACK PEARL – DECK – EVENING

The ship sails across the sand with the self-assurance of a vessel that finds the distinction between sea and desert theoretical.

Joseph works on deck with his spiral notebook – the Moroccan flag sticker faded but present. He draws diagrams. Consults Seiko. Sketches the weapon's architecture.

PROTO-ADAMANTIUM: the theoretical alloy that appears in the metallurgical traditions of multiple dimensions. Always described. Never built. Because no single dimension has ever had all its required components simultaneously.

VIBRANIUM. ADAMANTIUM. URU from Asgard. MANDALORIAN BESKAR. NTH METAL. PROMETHIUM. And the binding agent: the element that makes the combination stable rather than catastrophically reactive.

WEEZY GOLD. Without it, the alloy destroys itself during forging. With it: something that absorbs all directed energy, survives cosmic-scale force, indestructible by any means in any surveyed dimension.

SEIKO
(looking at the diagram)

What does it do? The finished weapon.

JOSEPH

It ends things. Epstein's network
and Kronos's temporal architecture.
Both simultaneously, through a single
application at the right point.

SEIKO

How confident are you?

JOSEPH

I'm working on it. That's always
the right answer.

JACK SPARROW passes them for the third time this evening.
He says nothing. He continues on. He is not leaving.

SEIKO

(quietly)

He knows more than he's indicating.

JOSEPH

Most people do.

CUT TO:

ACT TEN: THE PALACE OF OBSERVATION

EXT. THE IN-BETWEEN — THE WATCHER'S PALACE — DAY THREE

The palace appears on the third day. Suspended without foundation at the geometric center of the in-between. Enormous — slightly wrong in its proportions, as if built by something that has observed architecture for millennia and understood its elements without fully absorbing its grammar. Its walls are built from the physical sediment of dimensional contact — the residue of every world that has ever touched another, accumulated here over time until accumulation became structure.

The Black Pearl docks against it. They go in.

INT. THE WATCHER'S PALACE — ENTRANCE HALL

Two hundred feet of height. From the ceiling hang thousands of MIRRORS — alive, active, each showing a different world at a different moment. Running in real time.

A market in Lagos in a dimension where the climate changed differently three centuries ago. A classroom where the students are bioluminescent. A version of the MPA lobby where the memorial wall is larger.

Joseph stops at the last one. He looks at the memorial with fewer names — the version of this where fewer people died. He allows himself, precisely and briefly, the feeling of: there was a way this could have been different. Then he moves.

LARRY THE WATCHER — ageless, white-clothed, unhurried — approaches from the far end of the hall.

JOSEPH

Larry the Watcher.

LARRY

(genuine surprise)

You know me.

JOSEPH
I know of you. Beings who observe
the multiverse. Without intervening.

LARRY
We observe. Come – there is food.

INT. THE WATCHER'S PALACE – THE LONG TABLE – LATER

They eat. Food from everywhere – specific dishes from specific worlds, each representing a tradition that has developed over centuries. Everything tastes precisely as it should, because the in-between accumulates things at the level of their essential nature.

LARRY watches them eat with the manner of someone for whom watching is the primary mode of being.

Joseph waits. When the meal is done:

JOSEPH
I need the Weezy Gold.

LARRY
I know.

JOSEPH
You have it.

LARRY
I do.

JOSEPH
Will you give it to me?

Larry looks at his hands – the hands of someone who has been holding something for a very long time and is about to put it down.

LARRY
First – there's something I need to tell you. A confession. Something I did. Something I'm responsible for.

The table goes quiet.

LARRY

(choosing each word with the
precision of someone who has
rehearsed this)

The vortex. Over Cambridge. The night
of September third. The one that
pulled you through, triggered the
barrier collapse, began everything.

He looks directly at Joseph.

LARRY

I created it.

Silence. SEIKO goes completely still. Batman goes still in
a different way. Joseph is very controlled.

JOSEPH

Why.

LARRY

The multiverse framework had been
approaching catastrophic failure for
centuries. The failure was certain –
the only question was when and in
what form. When it came, uncontrolled
and simultaneous, everything would
become everything else in a single
instant. All of it. All of us. Gone.

JOSEPH

So you triggered it yourself.
Controlled
manner. With a stabilizing force at
the center.

LARRY

Yes.

JOSEPH

Without telling that force.

LARRY

Yes.

JOSEPH

Without giving that force any choice.

LARRY

Yes.

The word falls three times. Each one the same weight.

Joseph stands. He walks around the table. He stands in front of Larry.

He speaks very quietly. With the control of someone who knows what they feel and has decided what to do with it.

JOSEPH

You watched. While my mother died.
While Seiko was wounded again and
again. While Yara was taken. While
people died in every city where
the battles happened. You watched
all of it. From here. Through those
mirrors.

LARRY

I watch. It is my nature.

JOSEPH

But you intervened once. To start it.

LARRY

Yes.

JOSEPH

Then you chose a moment to act and
every other moment not to. And every
consequence – every death, every
wound, every cost – that is yours.
You chose it for me without asking.
I want you to understand that clearly.

He does not look away from Larry.

JOSEPH

I'm not going to thank you. I'm not going to forgive you. I'm going to carry what it cost for the rest of my life, and it will cost every day, and you chose that for me.

A pause.

JOSEPH

And none of that changes what needs to be done. Will you give me the Weezy Gold?

Larry looks at him. The look of something that has witnessed ten thousand years of events and has just witnessed something that did not appear in any of its calculations.

LARRY

Yes.

He reaches into his coat. A SMALL GLASS CONTAINER. Inside: a material that is neither powder nor liquid — GOLD, not the metal, but the principle. The essence of binding. The property that makes separate things into one coherent whole without destroying what each one was.

He holds it out.

LARRY

(quietly)

And — I am sorry. For what it cost.
I still believe the outcome justified
the cost. And I am sorry.

Joseph picks up the container. Its weight is not physical.

He puts it in his coat pocket.

As he turns: a young woman in the doorway. Has been watching.

ISABELLA — twenties, dark-haired, with her father's complete attention but with something added — something

warmer, something that has chosen to feel rather than only observe – comes into the room when Joseph looks at her.

JOSEPH

(recognizing something in her
face)

Isabella.

She looks at him. She looks at Seiko.

SEIKO looks at her with the expression of someone who has just encountered a piece of information that requires significant reorganization of their existing frameworks.

This will matter later.

CUT TO:

ACT ELEVEN: THREE ROOMS AND A VENTILATION SYSTEM

**INTERCUT WITH THE PREVIOUS SEQUENCE — HAPPENING
SIMULTANEOUSLY**

INT. EPSTEIN'S FACILITY — YARA'S ROOM — SIX WEEKS IN

A room. Not cruel — a bed, books chosen with the disturbing precision of someone who has assessed her preferences from a distance, a window onto an interior courtyard that receives three hours of direct sunlight. The specific comfort of a cage built by someone who understands that comfort and captivity are not mutually exclusive.

YARA has been here for six weeks. She has spent the time the way she spends everything: systematically.

Week one: assessment. She is a psychologist. She studies exactly this type of situation — the human response to controlled environments. She applies everything she knows professionally to her own situation with the clinical precision of someone conducting a case study in which she is also the subject.

Weeks two and three: structure. A daily routine built with the precision of someone constructing a habitable interior from available materials. Scheduled reading. Physical exercise. Mental exercises from her research. She treats the maintenance of her own psychological functioning as a professional responsibility. She is very good at her job.

Week four: the ventilation system.

Three rooms away, connected by a duct that carries sound better than it was designed to:

GUMBALL
(through the vent — barely
audible)
Are you okay?

YARA

Yes. Are you?

GUMBALL

I'm going to be honest. I miss Darwin a lot. But otherwise I'm okay. I've been doing pushups.

YARA

How many?

GUMBALL

More than zero. Less than I'd like. But I do all of them that I can.

YARA

That's the right approach.

They establish a schedule. Twice a day. They talk through the ventilation system for three weeks.

GUMBALL tells her about Darwin with the precision of someone preserving something important. The way Darwin hums when processing information – a soft sound that changes pitch depending on complexity. The way he tilts his head when listening to something sad, slightly to the left, because he doesn't want you to see it in his face. The way his body always finds the position slightly between Gumball and whatever might be a threat, without making it look intentional.

Yara listens. Asks follow-up questions.

Both of them understand: they are keeping the specific people they love alive in the space between them. So that when they get out, those people will still be real.

Week five:

INT. EPSTEIN'S FACILITY – YARA'S ROOM – DAY

The door opens. GHISLAINE MAXWELL – fifties, careful posture, the stillness of someone who has spent two years in confined spaces – enters and sits.

MAXWELL

(before Yara can speak)
I'm not here as his representative.

YARA
(measuring her)
Then why are you here?

MAXWELL
I've been in a cell for two years.
In that time I thought about things
I hadn't allowed myself to think
about before. The specific people.
Their names. What happened to them.
The complete architecture of what
I participated in.

A pause with something real in it.

MAXWELL
(looking up)
Your Joseph said something, about
a year before the first war. He said:
there's always a moment when you can
still choose. I am looking at the
door. I am choosing.

YARA
What do you want?

MAXWELL
To get you out. And to give you the
complete account structure. Every
network node. Every leverage file.
Every location. The map to all of it.
The key to the center crystal's
location. Everything.

YARA
Why should I trust you?

MAXWELL
(honestly)
You shouldn't. Not completely.
Trust me enough to listen. And tell
Joseph — because you will see him —

that the map is in the accounts.
He will know what that means.

She goes to the door. Stops.

MAXWELL
Three days. Don't draw attention
before I come back.

She leaves.

Gumball through the ventilation:

GUMBALL
(barely audible)
Was that who I think it was?

YARA
Yes.

GUMBALL
Do you believe her?

Yara thinks about Joseph saying there's always a moment
when you can still choose – said with the conviction of
someone who has tested this principle and found it
consistent.

YARA
Yes. I think she means it.

GUMBALL
That's inconvenient. It's much simpler
when people stay the thing you first
decided they were.

YARA
I know.

GUMBALL
(after a pause)
Is Joseph okay?

YARA
(without hesitation)
He's somewhere building something.
That's what he does when the options
run out — he builds the option that
doesn't exist yet.

GUMBALL
That's a good person to have looking
for you.

YARA
Yes. It is.

Three days later: Maxwell opens the door. In forty minutes
they are through a dimensional fracture and on the other
side.

Yara stands on the other side. She breathes the air of a
different dimension.

She thinks: I told Gumball he was building something. Six
thousand light-years away in subspace transit, Joseph Al-
Mithali is holding a container of gold that has no name in
any language anyone here speaks.

She was right.

CUT TO:

ACT TWELVE: THREE THINGS KNOWN UPON WAKING

INT. THE BLACK PEARL — JOSEPH'S CABIN — NIGHT

Joseph sits on the narrow bunk. ISABELLA is in the doorway — the Watcher's daughter who has chosen to feel rather than only observe.

He has the container of Weezy Gold in his hands. The material inside moves with the slow deliberation of something with its own opinion about time.

JOSEPH

What do you know about it? You've been here longer than anyone.

ISABELLA

(entering — sitting across — with the quality of someone saying what they have thought carefully about)

It's not a material. It's a property. The property of making separate things into one coherent thing without destroying what each one is. Every alloy has a binding principle. The Weezy Gold is the binding principle for an alloy that has never been completed because no one has ever had all the components in the same place at the same time.

JOSEPH

Until now.

ISABELLA

Until now.

A pause.

JOSEPH

Your father told me he still believes

the outcome justified the cost.

ISABELLA

(carefully)

He does believe this. Whether it's true is a different question from whether he believes it.

JOSEPH

What do you believe?

She considers this with the seriousness it deserves.

ISABELLA

I believe the question of whether the outcome justified the cost is not yours to carry. The cost is yours. The outcome is yours. The question is his. He chose the cost for you. The least he can do is carry his own question about it.

JOSEPH

(after a long moment)

She called every Sunday.

ISABELLA

(understanding immediately)

I know.

JOSEPH

That's what I keep returning to. Not the large things. The Sunday calls. The fig tree photographs. The specific instruction to drink more water than I think I need. The recurring things. The things that say: I'm still here. Regardless.

ISABELLA

The recurring things are the structure. The large events are the content. You can feel the structure even after the content is gone.

A pause.

JOSEPH

She would have found the name Weezy
Gold completely ridiculous.

Isabella almost smiles.

ISABELLA

Would she have been wrong?

JOSEPH

(a genuine small laugh – the
first in a very long time)
No. She would not have been wrong.

He puts the container away.

JOSEPH

We need to get back. Build the
weapon. End this.

ISABELLA

Are you ready?

JOSEPH

(standing)
I'm working on it. That's always
the right answer.

He goes. Isabella remains in the doorway – she decided,
when she walked away from her father's palace, that she was
done observing without involvement. She has not regretted
it. She follows him onto the deck.

INT. THE BLACK PEARL – JOSEPH'S CABIN – THAT NIGHT

Joseph sleeps. Genuinely, for the first time in weeks.

The dream: the desert again. The golden light moving in the
sky with direction and purpose. This time it lands. It
lands where he stands.

It does not burn. It informs.

Joseph wakes. He sits up.

He knows three things:

ONE: Epstein is still operational. But Yara and Gumball are free.

TWO: The final confrontation will require the weapon.

THREE: He has what the weapon requires.

He writes nothing down. These are not things he will forget.

He goes back to work.

CUT TO:

EPILOGUE: WHAT THE LETTER KNEW

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MONITORING ROOM — WEEKS LATER

Joseph and Seiko. Back on Earth. The monitoring room. The screens. The mint tea.

YARA at her station — eight days back, exactly herself. She does not need to be asked how she is. She shows you by the quality of attention she brings to her work.

GUMBALL is with DARWIN. Darwin has not let him out of comfortable proximity since the extraction. He keeps finding small reasons to be in whatever room Gumball is in. Gumball has not pointed this out. He understands what it is.

Seiko pulls up the Time Tracker letter analysis.

SEIKO

The handwriting. I identified it in the first hour of analysis. The specific quality of the characters, the perfectly consistent pressure, the absence of micro-variations that even highly practiced human handwriting contains. Something wrote this with the consistency of a system. Or someone who has been observing so long their movements have become system-like.

JOSEPH

The paper is from no catalogued dimension.

SEIKO

Correct. Carbon structure from multiple different dimensions. The ink: old in ways that don't correspond to any single timeline.

Joseph reads the letter again. HE WILL STRIKE AT WHAT YOU LOVE BEFORE HE STRIKES AT YOU.

He had read this as a future warning. He thinks: I read the sentence correctly and I read it wrong simultaneously. Both were true.

JOSEPH

Time Tracker. What do we know?

SEIKO

In dimensional folklore across twenty-three surveyed realities: a recurring figure whose function is to observe specifically the points where action alters what would otherwise have happened. They track the agents – people whose choices alter the direction of things enough to be worth recording.

JOSEPH

(slowly)

The letter was addressed to me by name and title. Which means whoever sent it has been tracking me specifically. For long enough to know to write before it began.

SEIKO

(immediately following)

Isabella.

JOSEPH

She left the palace. Not bound by the non-intervention principle anymore. She could have sent this. Months before we met her.

Joseph will ask her. Eventually. She will neither confirm nor deny. Which will be its own kind of answer.

The letter stays in his pocket throughout everything that follows.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — JOSEPH'S OFFICE — NIGHT

Joseph at his desk. Late. Manhattan through the window. The mint tea cold beside him.

He opens the spiral notebook to a new page. He writes:

WHAT WE KNOW:

1. Epstein's network has twenty-three nodes. All leveraged. All containable.
2. The center crystal maintains network stability. Destroying nodes alone is insufficient.
3. The weapon requires: Proto-Adamantium + Weezy Gold. Location for forging: Earth-2397.
4. Kronos is contained. Forty percent power. Rising.
5. Epstein knows we're coming. He has always known. This time we let him.

He pauses. Then, in different handwriting:

WHAT MATTERS:

The work is ours. Whatever they do to us — the work is always ours first.

He closes the notebook.

He looks at the skyline. The city below, continuing — indifferent to everything above it and below it, simply existing.

He picks up his cold tea. Drinks it anyway. He thinks: yes. All right. Yes.

He thinks about the recurring things. The Sunday calls. The fig tree. The instruction to drink more water than you think you need. These were not context. These were the thing itself.

He turns off the desk lamp.

He goes to sleep.

For the first time in a long time — genuinely — he goes to sleep.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE PERFECT JOSEPH AND GUMBALL: THE MULTIVERSAL SAGA
PART TWO: THE DEVIL YOU DON'T KNOW

*"The evil you cannot see is not in power.
It is in the architecture."*

*For Seiko Toast. The best friend anyone ever had.
For Fatima Al-Mithali.
Who called every Sunday. Regardless.*

FADE OUT.

POST-CREDITS SCENE

INT. KRONOS'S TEMPORAL CONTAINMENT — SOMEWHERE OUTSIDE TIME

The temporal lock. A space outside normal time, containing something that has never before been contained because nothing before this had the specific combination of capabilities required.

KRONOS exists in the lock. He is thinking.

He has been thinking since Kilimanjaro. The same thought, examined from every angle: I had not fully modeled for the relationship.

He had modeled for the cosmic energy. For the tactical capabilities. For the Frozen Time Fragment. He had not modeled for what sixty seconds would accomplish at forty percent against three of the most formidable beings in the surveyed realities working in concert — because he had not fully understood that the boy would use the sixty seconds not to protect himself but to create conditions in which others could be fully themselves.

An error. He has not made errors of this magnitude in ten thousand years.

The source of the error: the relationship. The boy is not the strength — he is the condition under which strength becomes possible. He builds the architecture in which other people become their best versions. This is significantly more difficult to defeat than strength, because you cannot defeat it by defeating him. You would have to defeat everyone he has ever helped become more fully themselves.

That is, Kronos reflects with the genuine intellectual pleasure of someone who has learned something genuinely new, an essentially different category of adversary.

He examines the containment field. He looks at where the interaction between Strange's magic and Harry's technique creates a resonance that will, over time, introduce a micro-fracture. Small. Almost invisible. Requiring time to develop.

Kronos has time.

He has always had time.

KRONOS

(to himself – with the
clinical interest he brings
to all analyses, including
the analysis of his own
defeat)

Forty percent now. Rising. I have time.
I have always had time. And the boy
will keep building his architecture.
And when he has built it completely –

He looks at the micro-fracture.

KRONOS

(almost – almost – with
something adjacent to
admiration)

Then we will see what the architecture
is made of. What it costs. And whether
it holds.

He smiles.

SMASH TO BLACK.

THE PERFECT JOSEPH AND GUMBALL: THE MULTIVERSAL SAGA

PART THREE: THE BREAKING POINT

COMING SOON

END OF PART TWO

CAST — PART TWO: THE DEVIL YOU DON'T KNOW

YOUSSEF BOUTAHRI — JOSEPH AL-MITHALI / 'The Perfect Joseph'
JAHZIR BRUNO — SEIKO TOAST
JORDYN RAYA JAMES — YARA GORDON
ABBY RYDER FORTSON — ISABELLA — Daughter of the Watcher
TOM CRUISE — LARRY THE WATCHER
JACOB HOPKINS — GUMBALL WATTERSON (Voice)
TERREL RANSOM JR. — DARWIN WATTERSON (Voice)
GIANCARLO ESPOSITO — KRONOS — Master of Temporal Dimensions
BILL SKARSGÅRD — JEFFREY EPSTEIN / 'THE DEVIL'
RASHIDA JONES — GHISLAINE MAXWELL
JOHNNY DEPP — CAPTAIN JACK SPARROW
ROBERT DOWNEY JR. — TONY STARK / IRON MAN
BEN AFFLECK — BATMAN / BRUCE WAYNE
HENRY CAVILL — SUPERMAN / CLARK KENT
CHRIS HEMSWORTH — THOR
GAL GADOT — WONDER WOMAN
BENEDICT CUMBERBATCH — DOCTOR STRANGE
IAN MCKELLEN — GANDALF THE GREY
DANIEL RADCLIFFE — HARRY POTTER
EMMA WATSON — HERMIONE GRANGER
CHADWICK BOSEMAN — BLACK PANTHER
MARK RUFFALO — BRUCE BANNER / THE HULK
RALPH FIENNES — VOLDEMORT
HUGH JACKMAN — WOLVERINE
EZRA MILLER — THE FLASH
JASON MOMOA — AQUAMAN
RAY FISHER — CYBORG
KEANU REEVES — JOHN WICK
MAHERSHALA ALI — BLADE
NISRINE ERRADI — FATIMA AL-MITHALI
ROSHDY ZEM — HASSAN AL-MITHALI
MERYEM TOUZANI — NADIA AL-MITHALI
HIROYUKI SANADA — KENJI TOAST
MICHELLE YEOH — MIYUKI TOAST

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من ضعف واحد ولدت قوة لا نهائية"

"From one weakness was born infinite power."

SUPPLEMENTAL: THE TWENTY-THREE NODES

SHOWING SIMULTANEOUSLY WITH THE FIRST THREE ACTS

INT. EPSTEIN'S NODE SEVEN — ZURICH — NIGHT

A private bank. After hours. The kind of building that keeps its most important business for after the public doors close and the ordinary machinery of finance has been locked away for the evening.

A MAN — fifties, impeccably dressed, with the careful posture of someone who has spent thirty years cultivating an image of unassailability — sits across a table from a phone. The phone is playing a recording. The recording is of him. The recording is of things he did, and said, and arranged, over a period of seven years, that he believed were unrecorded.

He believed this because the person who arranged the recordings told him they were unrecorded. This was the arrangement. This is always the arrangement.

The phone stops playing.

A voice on the other end of the line says:

EPSTEIN

(V.O. — pleasant,
unremarkable, the voice of
someone your memory cannot
quite hold onto)

The International Monetary
Stabilization
Fund vote. It happens Thursday. You
will vote against the oversight
measure.
Not loudly. Not visibly. Simply:
against.

The man at the table opens his mouth.

EPSTEIN

(V.O. - gently)

I know what you're going to say.
Don't say it. You've been wanting
to say it for four years and every
time you stop yourself because you
know the answer already.

The man closes his mouth.

EPSTEIN

(V.O.)

Thursday. Against. That's all.

The line closes. The man sits alone in the private bank. He
thinks about the recording. He thinks about what Thursday
means. He votes against.

This is Node Seven. It has operated precisely this way for
eleven years. Node Seven has never met Epstein in person.
Node Seven believes - incorrectly - that it is one of only
two or three people in this arrangement. Node Seven is
number seven of twenty-three.

INT. EPSTEIN'S NODE TWELVE - WASHINGTON D.C. - SAME NIGHT

A senator's private office. Late. The senator is not there.
Her chief of staff - KAREN, forty-one, brilliant,
exhausted, the specific exhaustion of someone who has been
making complex ethical calculations for so long they have
stopped noticing they are doing it - is reading a file.

The file appeared on her desk this evening. She does not
know who put it there. She knows what it contains. She
knows what the appearance of this file means.

She picks up her phone. She dials. She says:

KAREN

The infrastructure committee vote.
We'll table the cybersecurity
amendment.

She listens to the response.

KAREN

I understand. Yes.

She closes the phone. She sits for a moment. She makes the specific calculation that Node Twelve has been making for six years: the cost of compliance versus the cost of exposure. The calculation always produces the same answer.

She picks up her pen. She makes the note. She tables the amendment.

This is Node Twelve. Node Twelve has never caused Epstein any difficulty. Nodes that cause difficulty become nodes that are closed – not through violence but through a different application of the same mechanism. Compliance is simpler. Node Twelve has always understood this.

INT. EPSTEIN'S NODE SEVENTEEN – LONDON – SAME NIGHT

A media executive's home office. Private. His family asleep upstairs.

He is reading a story. Not the one his newsroom is planning to run. A different story – a story about him, about what he has done, about the specific decisions he made over eighteen months four years ago that he has spent four years trying to believe were more defensible than they were.

He has been reading versions of this story for six years. Epstein sends him a new version every six months. Sometimes with new details. Sometimes with the same details organized differently. The new organization reveals something the previous organization had obscured.

Tonight's version is the most detailed yet.

He picks up the phone.

MEDIA EXEC

The investigative piece on the MPA's financial structure. We're going to delay publication. Pending further verification.

He listens.

MEDIA EXEC

Indefinitely. Yes.

He closes the phone. He sits in his private office while his family sleeps upstairs and understands, not for the first time and not for the last, exactly what he is and what he has become.

This is Node Seventeen. Node Seventeen controls what eighteen million people read every morning about the organizations that exist to protect them. Node Seventeen has been controlling this, at Epstein's direction, for six years. The stories that don't run. The stories that run late. The framing of the stories that do run.

The architecture is invisible. That is the point of architecture — it works by being invisible. You don't notice the load-bearing walls until they're gone.

**INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SEIKO'S ANALYSIS STATION —
SIMULTANEOUSLY**

SEIKO at his station. Three a.m. He has been running the network analysis for six hours. He has identified Nodes Seven, Twelve, and Seventeen through a method he developed specifically for this architecture — not tracking Epstein, but tracking the specific pattern of coordinated decisions made by powerful people in coordinated timeframes that they would each independently describe as their own judgment.

When seven unconnected powerful people make decisions that benefit the same undisclosed third party within the same seventy-two-hour window, four times a year, for eleven years — this is not coincidence. This is architecture.

He has identified eighteen of the twenty-three nodes. He has mapped the connection patterns. He has not yet identified the center crystal — the node that maintains the system's coherence — because the center crystal is, by design, the part of the architecture that looks like nothing at all.

He works. His right shoulder is starting to hurt. He does not acknowledge this. He works.

At 4:47 a.m. he finds something.

Not the center crystal. Something adjacent to it. A pattern of financial transfers, all small, all individually

unremarkable, all passing through a specific class of charitable foundation – the kind of foundation that exists in every major jurisdiction, that processes billions in legitimate charitable giving, that is audited thoroughly and regularly, that appears in every due diligence report as a clean, well-governed institution.

Unless you look at the specific subset of transfers that flow through it at three-month intervals in amounts that are always precisely one percent of a much larger transaction happening simultaneously in a different jurisdiction.

One percent of a billion is ten million. Ten million moving through a charitable foundation at three-month intervals for eleven years is four hundred and forty million dollars. Moving through a clean, well-governed, thoroughly-audited institution.

Seiko looks at this number.

He looks at it for a long time.

He starts cross-referencing the recipient accounts.

He finds the map.

CUT TO:

INTERLUDE: THE TEN THOUSAND YEARS

KRONOS'S TEMPORAL PERSPECTIVE — NON-LINEAR

EXT. ANCIENT EGYPT — 8000 B.C. — KRONOS'S FIRST MEMORY

Before Kronos was Kronos, he was something else. Something that had not yet understood what it was.

He stands at the edge of what will become the Nile Valley, watching the water carve a canyon into the desert over centuries that pass, from his perspective, in the time it takes a human to draw a breath. He watches civilizations form and collapse and reform in the space of an afternoon. He watches the specific trajectory of how things develop — not from the outside, not as a historian cataloguing events, but from inside time, seeing how each moment generates the next, how causality moves through events like water through sand.

He is not yet ten thousand years old. He is, in the way of things that develop slowly toward their nature, still becoming what he will be.

He has a question. He has been forming it for three hundred years and has only now found the words for it:

If you can see how everything develops — if you can see every moment and its consequence — why can't you simply choose the moments that lead to the best outcome? Why is the multiverse permitted to develop chaotically, producing catastrophe after catastrophe, when someone with the right capability could simply arrange the sequence differently?

He has been carrying this question for three hundred years.

He is about to spend nine thousand seven hundred years looking for the answer.

INT. KRONOS'S TEMPORAL PERSPECTIVE — 5000 B.C.

He tries, for the first time, to alter a sequence.

A drought. A specific valley in what will become the Fertile Crescent. He can see — looking ahead — that the drought will last eleven years and the civilization living in this valley will not survive it. He can see — looking at the temporal lattice — a single point: a moment three years before the drought's worst year when a specific decision made by a specific person will send the community in the wrong direction.

He reaches into that moment. He alters the decision. He does it carefully, precisely, with the specific skill of someone who has been studying causality for three thousand years.

He watches what happens.

The drought still comes. The community survives it — barely, with difficulty, with cost. The specific cost is different from the cost he prevented: instead of the eleven-year drought eliminating the community, the community survives the drought but the decisions made during it create a generation of people who are harder, more territorial, less open to the cooperative arrangements that will become necessary when the next crisis arrives forty years later.

He has not improved the outcome. He has changed it. The change is not better or worse — it is different. The community exists that otherwise wouldn't have. The community is also different from what it would have been. Both things are true simultaneously.

He sits with this for five hundred years.

His conclusion: the problem is not the capability to intervene. The problem is the information required to know whether an intervention is an improvement. Which requires knowing what 'improvement' means. Which requires a standard. Which requires someone to define the standard.

He decides: he will be the one to define it.

This is the decision that made him Kronos.

INT. KRONOS'S TEMPORAL PERSPECTIVE — 1000 B.C.

He has been building his vision of the standard for seven thousand years. It is precise. It is internally consistent.

It has been tested against every major historical event he has been able to examine.

His standard: the maximum number of conscious beings able to sustain experience of meaningful existence over the longest possible time horizon. Not happiness — experience. Not safety — meaning. The specific quality of existence that makes existence worth having.

He has calculated, using this standard, applied to the entire history of the multiverse that he can observe, that the current system — in which reality is permitted to develop without arrangement — produces approximately thirty-two percent of the maximum potential meaningful experience. Thirty-two percent.

Which means sixty-eight percent of all possible meaningful experience has been wasted. Is being wasted. Will continue to be wasted for as long as the current system operates.

He has been carrying this knowledge for seven thousand years.

He has spent the most recent two thousand years building the capability to change it.

INT. KRONOS'S TEMPORAL PERSPECTIVE — THE PRESENT

The Cambridge vortex. The barrier collapse. The boy on the ice.

He has been watching this development for three years. He understands, with the specific analytical clarity of something that has been studying this kind of development for ten thousand years, what the boy is: a stabilizing force. A point of coherence around which the fractured multiversal system has begun to repair itself. A node of connection so powerful that it is changing the fundamental equation of how realities relate to each other.

This is not what Kronos wanted.

It is not that the boy's mission is wrong — the repair of the multiversal framework is genuinely good. But the method is wrong. The method is chaotic. Organic. Emergent. It relies on the relationships between specific people rather than on systematic arrangement. And systems built on

specific relationships are fragile in a way that systems built on structural necessity are not.

If the boy is removed – or if the relationships that make the boy effective are disrupted – the repair process stops. Everything collapses again. And the next stabilizing force might be three hundred years in arriving.

Kronos cannot permit this.

His solution: not destroy the boy. Replace the organic, fragile system of relationship-based repair with a structured, permanent system of arranged order. His system. The one he has been building for ten thousand years. The one that produces not thirty-two percent of potential meaningful experience but, by his calculations, eighty-seven.

He needs the boy to understand this. He needs the boy to see that the conflict is not between good and evil but between two different theories of how the good is best achieved.

He needs the boy to understand.

And if the boy cannot be made to understand – then the boy must be removed, and the system built anyway, and the eighty-seven percent will be the justification.

He reaches for the temporal lattice. He finds the thread that leads to the moment of maximum leverage. He pulls it toward him.

He begins.

**INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS – JOSEPH'S OFFICE – MUCH LATER –
AFTER LEARNING THIS**

Joseph sits with this information.

SEIKO has assembled it from a combination of the temporal analysis and what DOCTOR STRANGE was willing to share from the Sanctum's records on Kronos. It took four days. It is presented in a fourteen-page summary that Seiko has organized with the specific clarity of someone who understands that the most frightening information is the information that makes sense.

The information makes sense.

Joseph sits with what makes sense.

He thinks: if you have been building toward something for ten thousand years, and you believe with complete sincerity that what you are building will produce eighty-seven percent of potential meaningful experience rather than thirty-two percent, then you are not the villain. You are the person who has done the math.

He thinks: if you have done the math and the math says that specific people need to die for the eighty-seven percent to be achieved – then the math is wrong. Not the arithmetic. The premise. The specific failure of the premise is that it treats the loss of specific people as a cost that can be calculated and justified by the magnitude of the benefit.

He thinks about his mother.

He thinks: her life was not a cost. Her life was not a thirty-two-percent-of-potential data point. Her life was the thing that makes any percentage meaningful in the first place. You cannot calculate the value of what makes calculation possible. When you try, you get eighty-seven percent and the arithmetic is correct and the premise has destroyed everything it was trying to save.

He closes the summary. He goes back to work.

CUT TO:

PARALLEL THREAD: THE BEST FRIEND

SEIKO'S STORY — RUNNING THROUGH ALL ACTS

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SEIKO'S STATION — VARIOUS TIMES

A record of SEIKO TOAST's physical condition over the course of the events of Part Two, assembled from the MPA's medical monitoring system — a system Seiko himself designed and which he has been quietly disabling his own portion of for the past three months:

Week one: baseline. Right shoulder slightly strained from a dimensional transit incident six weeks prior. Managed without medical intervention. Not reported.

Week four: the shoulder has worsened. The specific worsening of an injury that is being asked to continue performing without rest. The shoulder is now pulling when he extends his arm above the horizontal. He has adjusted his working posture to avoid the extension. This adjustment is compensating for the injury by redistributing strain to the neck and upper back.

Week seven, Swiss Alps ambush: the shoulder takes a direct impact during the ambush — a blast that would, in a person who had reported the pre-existing injury, have been flagged for immediate medical assessment. Seiko does not report it. He manages the extraction coordination for forty-seven minutes from a position on one knee because standing is no longer comfortable.

Week eight, Kilimanjaro: fourteen hours of sustained tactical coordination. The shoulder is now a constant source of information — not pain, because he has reclassified it as information — that he processes alongside the fourteen data streams and forty-seven screens. He has found that focusing on the data has the specific effect of reducing the signal-to-noise ratio of the shoulder's input. He uses this.

Week nine, post-Kilimanjaro: the shoulder is damaged. Not strained, not pulled — damaged. He knows this. He has the anatomy knowledge to know this because he researched it

three weeks ago when the specific quality of the pain changed from muscular to something that suggested the joint itself was involved. He has not told anyone.

He has not told anyone because the work is not done.

INT. MPA MEDICAL WING — AFTER KILIMANJARO

DARWIN finds him.

Not immediately after — three days after. Darwin has been tracking, with the specific patience of someone who understands that timing matters, the moment when Seiko's work rate will drop below the level at which interrupting it is less costly than the cost of the injury continuing unaddressed.

He finds the moment at 2:17 a.m. on the third day post-Kilimanjaro, when Seiko's analysis response time increases by four percent — barely measurable, but measurable — indicating that the shoulder has progressed past the threshold where the compensatory posture is no longer fully compensating.

Darwin arrives at the station with a medical kit and says nothing. He sets it on the desk beside Seiko's screen. He sits in the adjacent chair.

Seiko does not look up.

SEIKO

I'm in the middle of the fracture point analysis.

DARWIN

(calmly)

I know. I can see the screen.
The fracture point analysis will
be more accurate in four hours
after the shoulder has been properly
treated than it will be in the
next four hours if it hasn't.

A pause. Seiko continues working.

DARWIN

(still calm)
I'm not going anywhere. You can
finish this section. I'll wait.

Seiko finishes the section. He starts the next one. Darwin
waits. At 2:41 a.m. Seiko puts down the stylus. He looks at
Darwin.

SEIKO
How long have you known?

DARWIN
Week four. I noticed the posture
adjustment.

A pause.

SEIKO
Why didn't you say something?

DARWIN
Because you weren't ready to hear it
yet. And because the work during
that period was more important than
the injury.

Seiko looks at this.

SEIKO
You made a cost-benefit calculation.

DARWIN
I made a you-specific calculation.
Which is different. The cost-benefit
calculation would have said: address
the injury in week four, the work
will be better for it. The you-specific
calculation said: Seiko cannot address
the injury in week four because he
won't. Not while the work needs doing.
So wait until the work has reached a
point where the injury's cost exceeds
the cost of the interruption.

A long pause.

SEIKO
That's a very specific calculation.

DARWIN
(simply)
You're a very specific person.

Darwin opens the medical kit. He treats the shoulder with the specific competence of someone who has been researching this particular injury for three weeks and has the resources of the MPA's medical database available to them.

Seiko lets him.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SEIKO'S STATION — 4:13 A.M. — LATER

The shoulder is better. Not healed — it will need two weeks of proper treatment to heal — but better. The specific quality of better that allows the compensatory posture to relax, which reduces the strain on the neck and upper back, which produces a measurable improvement in cognitive function that Seiko, if he were tracking his own metrics, would be able to quantify.

He is not tracking his own metrics. He is tracking the fracture point analysis.

At 4:13 a.m. he finds something he has not been looking for.

He finds ISABELLA.

Not in person — in the temporal data. In the specific pattern of information reaching the in-between palace, information about Joseph Al-Mithali specifically, information about his movements and decisions and the specific quality of his choices, compiled in a form that suggests someone has been compiling it for at least three years.

Someone who has been watching Joseph specifically. For three years. Before the Cambridge vortex. Before the barrier collapse. Before any of it.

Before.

Seiko looks at this.

He thinks: before the vortex. Before the vortex means someone knew the vortex was coming. Which means someone knew what the vortex would produce. Which means someone knew who Joseph Al-Mithali would become before the event that made him what he became.

Which means: the vortex was not an accident.

He files this. He continues working. He will tell Joseph when the time is right. He will tell Joseph when the work has reached the point where this information is useful rather than distracting.

He knows Joseph. He knows when the time is right.

He works.

**INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — SEIKO'S STATION — THE MORNING
JOSEPH RETURNS**

Joseph comes back from wherever the void has deposited them. He comes directly to the monitoring room. He does not go to his office, does not go to his room, does not eat or sleep. He comes to the monitoring room because this is where Seiko is and this is where the work is.

He stops when he sees Seiko.

He has not seen him in weeks — the time in the in-between was not the same time as here. He looks at Seiko with the specific attention of someone who has been worrying about a person from a distance and is now checking whether the worry was warranted.

The bandage above the left eye from the Swiss Alps ambush. The right shoulder that Darwin told him about, weeks ago, that Joseph has been carrying as a piece of unresolved concern since.

The specific quality of someone who has been working very hard for a very long time and has made himself responsible for not stopping.

Joseph walks to Seiko's station. He doesn't say anything for a moment. He looks at the screens.

JOSEPH
(quietly — not for the room)
How is your shoulder?

Seiko looks up. The specific expression of someone who has been waiting for this question and has prepared for it and finds, now that it's being asked, that he doesn't have as much of a prepared answer as he thought.

SEIKO
Better. Darwin treated it.

JOSEPH
When?

SEIKO
(a pause)
Three days ago. Post-Kilimanjaro.

Joseph looks at him. He does the calculation: the injury was active from at least week four. Kilimanjaro was week nine. Five weeks. Five weeks of working through a worsening injury on fourteen data streams and forty-seven screens and five simultaneous city battles.

JOSEPH
(very quietly — not anger,
something more complicated)
Why didn't you tell me?

SEIKO
Because you had enough to carry.

A long pause. The monitoring room humming around them. The screens cycling.

JOSEPH
Seiko.

SEIKO
Yes.

JOSEPH

You are — you're the thing that makes everything else possible. You understand this. If something happens to you because you decided I had enough to carry and didn't tell me —

He stops. He finds the words.

JOSEPH

I need to know. Whatever it is,
I need to know.

SEIKO

(after a moment)

I know. I'm sorry.

A beat.

SEIKO

(quietly)

You're back. The container worked.
The Weezy Gold is — that's actually
the most ridiculous name for
something this important.

Joseph almost smiles.

JOSEPH

She would have thought so too.

SEIKO

(gently)

I know. She would have been very
specific about why.

A pause. The room around them. The screens.

SEIKO

I missed her too. You know that.
She made me drink water at Sunday
calls. For two years. She insisted
on it. She said: put a glass of
water on your desk before we talk,

Seiko, because I know you won't
otherwise.

Joseph looks at him.

JOSEPH

Did you?

SEIKO

(simply)

Always.

They stand together in the monitoring room. The screens
cycling. The mint tea available at all hours. The work, as
always, waiting.

CUT TO:

THE FORGE

EARTH-2397 — THREE WEEKS AFTER RETURNING FROM THE IN- BETWEEN

EXT. EARTH-2397 — SOMEWHERE IN THE AMERICAN WEST — DAWN

Earth-2397 is a dimension that developed differently at a specific branch point approximately two hundred years ago — the decision, in that world's version of the Industrial Revolution, to pursue metallurgy rather than chemistry as the primary driver of technological development. Two hundred years of that choice have produced a civilization that looks, from the outside, recognizably similar to the world Joseph grew up in, but that has, in the hands of its practitioners, a relationship with metal that no other dimension in the surveyed catalog can match.

The forge they have found is not in a city. It is in a valley in what, in this dimension, is still wilderness — a wide valley of red rock and high altitude where the specific combination of atmospheric conditions produces a kind of natural furnace effect in certain geological formations. The forge uses this. It has been using it for three hundred years.

It is operated by a woman named ELEANOR VANCE, sixty-seven, who is the seventh generation of her family to work this forge, and who has agreed to the request Joseph brought to her because she spent six months two years ago studying every available piece of information about the multiversal barrier collapse and reached her own conclusion about what it means and what needs to be done about it.

She told Joseph: I've been waiting for someone to come with this commission.

He told her: you knew someone was coming?

She said: I knew the commission was possible. I didn't know if anyone would ever be in a position to bring it.

INT. EARTH-2397 — THE FORGE — DAY ONE

The forge is inside a natural rock formation — a dome of stone approximately forty meters in diameter, with a central shaft that rises sixty meters to an opening at the top through which the atmospheric convection draws heat with a consistency and precision that no mechanical system has ever matched. The walls of the dome are covered in the accumulated residue of three hundred years of metallurgical work — layers of mineral deposits, each one the record of a specific commission, a specific material, a specific moment in the history of someone bringing Eleanor's family an impossible problem and asking them to solve it.

Joseph brings the components. Each one carried separately, because carrying them together would create a resonance effect that would damage whatever they're carried in. Batman has organized the logistics — seven separate couriers, seven separate routes, seven separate arrival windows, all coordinated to converge on the forge within a twenty-minute period.

VIBRANIUM from Wakanda — a gift from T'CHALLA, who said: if what you're building is what you say it is, then use it fully.

ADAMANTIUM — extracted from a dimensional fracture site in the Canadian shield where a deposit had been exposed by the barrier collapse.

URU from Asgard — THOR arrived with it personally, carrying it in a sealed container that he held with the specific care of someone transporting something that has feelings about being transported.

MANDALORIAN BESKAR — sourced through a contact in a dimension where the Mandalorian tradition has intersected with multiversal trade routes in interesting ways.

NTH METAL from Thanagar. PROMETHIUM from New Genesis.

And the WEEZY GOLD — in its small glass container, warm, moving slowly.

Eleanor examines each component with the attention of someone who has been working with impossible materials for forty years and has developed the specific sensory vocabulary for understanding them. She picks each one up. She feels it. She holds it near the central shaft and watches how it responds to the convective heat. She makes

notes in a notebook that appears to be the continuation of a series of notebooks going back several decades.

When she has examined all six primary components, she picks up the container of Weezy Gold.

She holds it for a very long time.

ELEANOR

(not looking up from the
container)

Where did you get this?

JOSEPH

From someone who had been holding
it for a long time. At the center
of everything.

She nods. She doesn't ask more. Some questions have answers that don't fit in the forge and are better left outside it.

ELEANOR

The forging takes three days. The
first day is preparation — the
components need to be brought to
the same temperature, which is
different for each of them and needs
to happen simultaneously. If any one
of them reaches its target temperature
while another hasn't, the binding
won't take.

JOSEPH

What does the Weezy Gold do?
Specifically. In the forging.

ELEANOR

It finds the specific frequency of
coherence that all six materials
share — not a property they have
individually, but a property that
exists in the relationship between
them. It activates that frequency.
Makes the relationship primary rather
than the individual materials. Binds

them into something that is more
coherent than any of them separately.

JOSEPH

And the result — what does it do?
What is it?

Eleanor looks at him. The look of someone being asked a
question they have been thinking about for a long time.

ELEANOR

The result is something that has
the binding property of the Weezy
Gold but at a structural scale.
Something that, when it makes contact
with a system built on leverage —
on the forced relationship between
things that don't want to be related —
replaces the forced relationship with
the natural one. Dissolves the
architecture of coercion and leaves
the underlying materials free to
find their own coherence.

JOSEPH

(quietly)

It doesn't destroy the network.
It dissolves what holds it together.

ELEANOR

Exactly. Every node becomes free.
Every piece of leverage loses its
force simultaneously. Not because
the information is destroyed —
the information still exists — but
because the architecture that makes
the information dangerous is gone.

Joseph looks at the components on the forge table.

JOSEPH

And Kronos's temporal architecture?

ELEANOR

Kronos's architecture is built on

the same principle — forced
relationships
between moments that don't naturally
belong together. Time forced into
arrangements it hasn't chosen.
The weapon finds the natural coherence
of those moments and releases them
back to it. Kronos's architecture
dissolves because its foundation
isn't there anymore.

She picks up the Weezy Gold container. She holds it up to
the light from the shaft above — the specific warm,
convective light of the forge's natural system.

ELEANOR

Who named this?

JOSEPH

I don't know. The name came to
me in a dream. I didn't question it.

ELEANOR

(with the specific warmth of
someone recognizing
something)

Good. The best names come that way.
My great-grandmother named the
forge. She said the name came to
her in a dream and she wrote it
down and never questioned it either.

JOSEPH

What's the forge's name?

ELEANOR

'The place where things become
what they were always going to be.'
She said it in one breath. As if
it were a single word.

She begins the preparation.

INT. EARTH-2397 — THE FORGE — DAY TWO

The forge at night is different from the forge during the day. The atmospheric convection changes with the temperature differential – at night, when the exterior cools faster than the rock dome, the convection reverses, drawing cold air down through the shaft and creating a specific kind of controlled cooling that is as important to the forging process as the heating.

Joseph sits outside the dome on the second night. ISABELLA beside him. The high-altitude desert sky above them – in this dimension, it has a slightly different quality, slightly more stars visible because the civilization's relationship with light pollution has been different for two hundred years.

JOSEPH

(looking at the sky)

Tell me about observing. What it actually is. Not the principle – the experience.

ISABELLA

(considering)

It's everything happening at once. Every world, every moment, all of it simultaneously available. The challenge is not finding things – everything is always right there. The challenge is knowing what to pay attention to. The challenge is caring.

JOSEPH

And you cared about me specifically.

ISABELLA

I noticed you specifically. Caring came after. The noticing came because you do something that very few people in any dimension I've observed do.

JOSEPH

What?

ISABELLA

You pay attention to other people
the way observers are supposed to
pay attention to everything. With
complete attention. Without judgment.
With the specific quality of someone
who is genuinely curious about who
the other person is, not who they
want them to be.

A pause.

ISABELLA

(continuing)

My father watches everything and
sees it all clearly and feels none
of it. You feel everything and
see it all clearly anyway. Those
are different things.

JOSEPH

Did you send the letter?

A pause. The high-altitude sky above them. The stars of a
dimension that developed differently.

ISABELLA

(after a moment)

I neither confirm nor deny.

JOSEPH

That's its own kind of answer.

ISABELLA

(almost — almost — a smile)

Yes. It is.

They sit under the stars. The forge working in the dome
behind them. The specific warmth of the convective cooling
reaching them — warm air from within the dome, meeting the
cold of the desert night, creating a thermal boundary that
is, if you're sitting at exactly the right point, perfectly
comfortable.

They are sitting at exactly the right point.

INT. EARTH-2397 – THE FORGE – DAY THREE – THE BINDING

The third day.

Eleanor has been working since before dawn. The six primary components are at their respective target temperatures – simultaneously, for the first time, held in balance by a combination of the forge's natural system and Eleanor's technical expertise and the specific accumulated wisdom of seven generations of her family's relationship with impossible materials.

Joseph stands in the doorway of the dome. He watches.

Eleanor opens the container of Weezy Gold. She holds it over the forge's central column – the point where all six components are in proximity, heated, prepared, waiting.

She pours the Weezy Gold in.

For a moment: nothing.

Then: the materials move. Not toward each other – into a relationship with each other. The specific difference is visible if you're watching carefully: forced movement closes the gap between things through external force. Natural movement closes the gap because the things discover they belong in proximity. The Weezy Gold finds the frequency they share. They move.

The forge fills with a light that is not fire. It is the same gold as the Weezy Gold – not the metal, but the principle. The light of binding. The light of things that were separate becoming what they were always going to be.

When it clears, Eleanor is holding the weapon.

It does not look like a weapon. It looks like a key.

Approximately thirty centimeters long. Slightly warm. It catches light from multiple moments simultaneously – not because it has been forged with temporal material, but because the Weezy Gold's binding property has given it a relationship with time that is different from ordinary matter's. It exists fully in the present but holds the resonance of every moment that went into its making.

Eleanor holds it out.

ELEANOR

(quietly)

It's done. Three days and seven generations and whatever it cost to get here.

Joseph takes it.

It is warm. Not from the forge — from something else. From the same quality the Weezy Gold had: the warmth of something that has been waiting to be what it is and has finally become it.

JOSEPH

What do I do with it?

ELEANOR

You put it in contact with the center crystal of the network. The weapon will do the rest. It knows what to do. That's what the Weezy Gold means — it knows what to do because it's made of the specific frequency that makes things coherent. It will find the network's frequency and dissolve it.

JOSEPH

And Kronos?

ELEANOR

The same. But you need to get it into contact with his temporal staff at the moment when his capacity is low enough for the weapon to overcome his resistance. The weapon doesn't destroy time. It restores natural temporal coherence. Kronos's architecture depends on forced temporal arrangements. The weapon dissolves the force. The arrangements return to their natural state. Kronos returns to being what he was before the architecture.

JOSEPH

What was he before the architecture?

ELEANOR

(looking at the forge)

Something that could see everything
and feel something about it. Something
that hadn't yet decided that the
feeling was a problem to be solved.

Joseph holds the weapon.

He thinks: he will feel something about this. He will feel
something about the man who took his mother and call it
analysis. He will feel something about the boy who refused
to become what he wanted and call it a problem to solve.

He thinks: the weapon doesn't punish. It restores. It gives
back what was taken from moments that were supposed to be
free.

He thinks: that's enough.

JOSEPH

(to Eleanor)

Thank you. For seven generations
of being ready for this.

ELEANOR

(simply)

Thank you for being the person
who brought it.

He goes.

CUT TO:

THE FINAL PREPARATION

MPA HEADQUARTERS — THE LAST WEEK

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — GRAND CONFERENCE HALL — FULL ASSEMBLY

Every hero. The full roster assembled for the first time since the Battle of Kilimanjaro. They are different from the last time they filled this room — not visibly, but in the specific way that people who have been through something together are different from who they were before it. They carry the knowledge of what it cost. They carry the knowledge that the cost was paid and they are still here.

Joseph at the front. The weapon on the table beside him — not displayed, not presented, simply there. Present. Waiting.

JOSEPH

The center crystal of Epstein's network is located in a dimensional pocket attached to his primary node. Ghislaine Maxwell has given us the authentication key. The pocket is accessible through a fracture point in lower Manhattan that we can reach in approximately forty minutes.

BATMAN pulls up a three-dimensional map — the dimensional pocket, the fracture point, the approach routes.

BATMAN

The pocket is defended. Epstein anticipated that the crystal would eventually be found — he always anticipated everything. The defense is not military. It's structural. The pocket exists at the intersection of eight separate dimensional fracture lines. Entering it incorrectly triggers a collapse that destroys

the crystal. The crystal is the map. Destroy the crystal before we've accessed it and the network survives indefinitely.

SEIKO

Maxwell's key authenticates the approach vector. If we enter on the correct vector, the defense systems recognize us as authorized and stand down. We have one approach. One. If we deviate from it by more than three degrees in any dimensional axis, the collapse triggers.

JOSEPH

So we don't deviate. Seiko will navigate the approach vector. I'll make contact with the crystal. The weapon does the rest.

TONY

And Kronos? His containment is holding but the micro-fracture Strange and Harry identified is expanding. He's at sixty-two percent capacity and rising.

JOSEPH

The weapon addresses both simultaneously. The network and Kronos's architecture share a structural property — both are built on forced arrangements. When we apply the weapon to the crystal, it sends a dissolution signal through every connected system. Including Kronos's temporal architecture.

DOCTOR STRANGE

You're sure about the simultaneity?

JOSEPH

(looking at the weapon)

Eleanor Vance is sure. I trust her.

The room absorbs this.

SUPERMAN

What about Epstein?

A beat. Joseph looks at the weapon. He looks at the room.

JOSEPH

Epstein told me how to find the crystal. He gave us what we needed to do this because it serves his interests. Destroying the network removes Kronos's operational infrastructure. It also removes Epstein's. After the crystal is gone, he's a man with a great deal of knowledge and no leverage. What happens to him after that is a question for courts and institutions that are now free from his influence, because his influence over them dissolves with the crystal.

BATMAN

He anticipated this too.

JOSEPH

Yes. He's already planning the next version of himself. He always is. That's not our concern today. Today we end this.

He picks up the weapon.

He holds it in both hands. The specific warmth of it. The warmth of something that knows what it is and what it's for.

JOSEPH

(to the room — the assembled heroes, sixty people who have been through Kilimanjaro and Antarctica and the Swiss Alps and London and Tokyo and

Paris and Sydney and
everything in between)
This started in Cambridge. In a
library. At three in the morning.
A crack in the air that pulled
me through before I understood
what I was being pulled toward.

He looks at the room.

JOSEPH

Everyone in this room chose to be
here. Every one of you. That choice
is what the weapon is made of.
Not the materials — the choice.
The decision to keep showing up
regardless of what it costs.
The Weezy Gold doesn't bind the
metal. It binds that.

He sets the weapon down.

JOSEPH

Let's go.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — CORRIDOR — BEFORE DEPARTURE

YARA finds him in the corridor.

She says nothing for a moment. She looks at him with the
specific quality of attention that she brings to things
that matter.

YARA

How are you?

He considers the question with the seriousness it deserves.
He does not say fine.

JOSEPH

I'm carrying several things
simultaneously. The grief and the
work and the specific feeling you
get when something that has been
building for a long time is finally

about to resolve.

YARA

That's a very complete answer.

JOSEPH

You asked a real question. You
always ask real questions.

A pause.

JOSEPH

She would have liked you. She asked
real questions too. She was very
specific about the difference between
a real question and a polite inquiry.
She said: a real question listens
to the answer. A polite inquiry
waits for its turn to speak.

YARA

(quietly)

She sounds like someone I would
have liked to know.

JOSEPH

Yes. She would have given you
specific feedback on your dissertation.
She would have found the analytical
framework impressive and then told
you the one place where the lived
experience doesn't match the model.
From twenty years in a hospital.
With specific examples.

Yara almost smiles.

YARA

I would have wanted to hear that.

JOSEPH

I know. So would I.

A long pause.

YARA

When this is done – when the network is gone and Kronos's architecture is dissolved – what do you do next?

JOSEPH

(thinking about this seriously)

I call my father. I call Nadia. I water the plants. I water the fig tree, which she said was listening, and I tell it to keep persisting. And then I figure out what comes after. One thing at a time.

YARA

That's a very good plan.

JOSEPH

She taught it to me.

He picks up the weapon. He goes.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS – CORRIDOR – SEIKO FINDS HIM

One more stop. SEIKO.

They have been friends since they were fourteen years old. In the specific way of friendships that form in the period of life when everything is being determined, the friendship has become a kind of foundation – not visible in the structure above it, but what everything above it rests on.

Seiko is waiting in the corridor. He has the specific posture of someone who has something to say and has organized it carefully.

SEIKO

Before you go. I need to tell you something I found three weeks ago. I waited until now because it wasn't useful before now.

JOSEPH

Tell me.

SEIKO

The person who sent the letter.
The Time Tracker. They've been
watching you since before Cambridge.
Before the vortex. Before any of it.
Which means whoever sent it knew
the vortex was coming. Which means
the vortex was not an accident.
Which means Larry the Watcher was
not the first to intervene. Someone
intervened before him. Someone sent
you a warning before the event
that made the warning necessary.

A pause.

JOSEPH

Isabella.

SEIKO

Most likely. Yes.

Joseph looks at this information.

JOSEPH

So she set the whole thing in motion.
Not Larry – Isabella. She sent
the letter before the vortex,
knowing the vortex was coming,
knowing what it would produce.

SEIKO

Yes.

JOSEPH

Which means she chose me specifically.
Before I was the person I became.

SEIKO

Yes. Or she saw what you would become
and decided the person you would

become was worth protecting by
giving them the information they
needed to survive becoming it.

A long pause.

JOSEPH
That's a very specific form of care.

SEIKO
Yes. It is.

Joseph looks at his best friend of six years.

JOSEPH
When this is done — your shoulder.
Proper treatment. Not Darwin with
a kit at two in the morning. Proper.
Two weeks. Minimum.

SEIKO
The analysis will —

JOSEPH
Two weeks. Minimum.

A beat. Seiko looks at him.

SEIKO
(simply)
Yes. Okay.

Joseph puts his hand on Seiko's shoulder — the good one. He
holds it there for a moment.

JOSEPH
(quietly)
You are the best friend anyone
ever had. I need you to know that.
Before I go.

Seiko looks at him. The expression of someone who has
received something they needed and did not know how to ask
for.

SEIKO

Come back.

JOSEPH

I will.

He goes.

CUT TO:

THE CENTER CRYSTAL

LOWER MANHATTAN — THE DIMENSIONAL POCKET

EXT. LOWER MANHATTAN — THE APPROACH POINT — NIGHT

A specific alley in lower Manhattan, between two buildings whose ages differ by a century and whose proximity creates a dimensional resonance that Seiko identified three weeks ago as the fracture point. There is nothing visually remarkable about it. This is characteristic of the fracture points that matter — the ones that are ordinary on the outside.

Joseph. Batman. Seiko. DOCTOR STRANGE. YARA. A small team — because what is required here is not force but precision, and precision does not scale with numbers.

SEIKO

(checking the approach
vector)

The authentication key is active.
The vector is seventeen degrees from
vertical, azimuth two-seven-three,
entering at the third resonance
frequency. I'll navigate. Stay within
one meter of me.

Nobody questions this. They have all learned, in different ways, that Seiko's navigational instructions are to be followed precisely and without editorial comment.

He takes a step into the air of the alley. In a specific direction that is not any of the directions the air of an alley is usually navigated. He steps.

The fracture opens.

INT. EPSTEIN'S DIMENSIONAL POCKET — CONTINUOUS

Inside the pocket: a space approximately the size of a large room, existing in the specific dimensional frequency that doesn't register on standard scans. The walls are not

physical — they are the boundary of the frequency itself, visible as a kind of luminescent edge.

At the center: the CENTER CRYSTAL.

It is not what any of them expected.

They expected something architecturally significant — something that looks like the heart of a system of this scale and complexity. What they find is approximately the size of a human heart, opaque, grey-blue, with a specific quality of light emanating from its interior that suggests enormous amounts of information being processed simultaneously. It pulses. Not with light — with data. The specific rhythm of twenty-three nodes all connected to a single source.

It looks, in the specific way of things that have been maintained with great care for a very long time, ordinary.

This is the point. It has been here, in this pocket, for thirty years. Ordinary. Unremarkable. The center of everything, disguised as nothing.

BATMAN

(low — scanning)

No defenses active. The authentication key worked.

DOCTOR STRANGE

The pocket itself is the defense.
Getting here was the obstacle.
Now that we're here — there's nothing
between us and it.

Joseph looks at the crystal. He walks toward it.

He is thinking about what it represents. Thirty years of this crystal sitting in this pocket, pulsing with data, maintaining the architecture of twenty-three nodes across seventeen dimensions. Thirty years of decisions made in private banks and senators' offices and media executive's home offices. Thirty years of the architecture of permission operating invisibly.

He is also thinking about something else.

He is thinking about the specific quality of what Epstein told him: I don't experience guilt. I experience analysis. He is thinking about what it means to have built something this comprehensive, this patient, this precisely designed to be durable — and to have built it without ever asking whether the thing it does to people is something you are permitted to do.

He reaches the crystal.

He holds the weapon beside it.

He does not use it yet.

JOSEPH

(to the crystal — very
quietly, not for anyone else
to hear)

Thirty years.

He looks at the pulsing data-light.

JOSEPH

(continuing)

Twenty-three people who went to
sleep every night for thirty years
knowing what they had agreed to.
Thousands of decisions they made
because they had no choice. Because
you had the recording. Because you
had the file. Because the architecture
made the alternative unthinkable.

He is not speaking to Epstein. He is speaking to the
system. To the thirty years of it.

JOSEPH

She called every Sunday. She watered
the fig tree. She told me to drink
more water than I think I need.
None of that was load-bearing.
None of that was leverage. None
of that was architecture. It was
just love. Just the recurring thing.
Just: I'm still here. Regardless.

A long pause.

JOSEPH

That's what this is for.

He places the weapon against the crystal.

The weapon does what it was made to do.

The Weezy Gold finds the frequency. Not the crystal's frequency — the frequency of the network itself. The frequency of twenty-three forced relationships maintained by the threat of revelation. It finds the specific resonance of coercion.

And it replaces it.

Not with nothing — with the natural resonance. The frequency of what those relationships would be if they were free. The frequency of information that is no longer a weapon because it is no longer secret. Because the architecture that made it dangerous has dissolved.

The crystal does not shatter. It does not explode. It simply stops pulsing. The data-light goes still. The twenty-three nodes, across seventeen dimensions, receive a signal that Seiko will spend six weeks analyzing in its entirety: the signal that says the architecture is gone. That what was held is released. That what was forced is free.

In a private bank in Zurich, a file on a screen disappears. In a senator's office in Washington D.C., a phone that always rang at specific intervals stops ringing. In a home office in London, a man sits for the first time in six years in a room where no recording of him exists anywhere that can be used against him.

In a dimensional pocket in lower Manhattan, the center crystal is grey and still and ordinary.

The architecture is gone.

Simultaneously — and DOCTOR STRANGE confirms this from his temporal sensors — Kronos's temporal architecture begins to dissolve. The forced arrangements between moments that don't naturally belong together, releasing back to their natural state. His prison weakening not from outside but from the foundation of what built it.

The room is very quiet.

YARA looks at Joseph. She says nothing. She doesn't need to.

BATMAN: 'Seiko. Status on Kronos.'

SEIKO

(over comm, from the
monitoring room)

The temporal architecture is
dissolving.

His capacity is dropping. From sixty-
two percent to - forty percent.

Thirty. Twenty.

A pause.

SEIKO

(V.O.)

He's at baseline. Pre-architecture.

He's - the containment is changing.

He's still contained but the nature
of the containment has changed.

Strange - you need to see this.

Strange goes. Joseph stays.

He looks at the grey, still crystal.

He thinks: it's done. The architecture is gone. The network
is gone. Kronos's plan is dissolved.

He thinks: she called every Sunday.

He thinks: it's not enough. It will never be enough. And
it's done.

Both things are true simultaneously.

He picks up the weapon. He puts it in his pocket. He turns
around. He walks back to where Seiko is waiting.

CUT TO:

WHAT REMAINS

THE TEMPORAL CONTAINMENT — AFTER THE DISSOLUTION

INT. KRONOS'S TEMPORAL CONTAINMENT — AFTER THE DISSOLUTION

The containment has changed.

It is still a containment — Strange and Harry's lock holds — but the nature of what it contains has changed. The specific quality of Kronos without his temporal architecture is like the quality of a fire without fuel: the capacity is still there, the potential still there, but the specific configuration that made it dangerous has been dissolved.

Kronos sits. Not stands — sits. He has been standing for eleven hours at Kilimanjaro and has been suspended in temporal stasis since. Now, for the first time in what feels to him like a very long time, he sits.

He is thinking.

Not the thinking he has been doing since Kilimanjaro — the calculation of the micro-fracture, the patient analysis of his eventual emergence, the tactical modeling of what comes next. That thinking is not available to him anymore. The architecture is gone. The temporal lattice he has been navigating for ten thousand years is still there — it has always been there, it is not his creation — but his ability to impose arrangements on it has dissolved with everything else.

He is experiencing time linearly for the first time in ten thousand years.

This is, he finds, different from what he expected.

He expected: loss. The specific experience of capability removed. He has spent ten thousand years knowing everything simultaneously and he expected the loss of that to feel like blindness.

What he finds instead: presence. The specific experience of being in one moment rather than all of them. The weight of now. The way this particular second has a quality – a texture, a specificity – that he had lost the ability to perceive when everything was available simultaneously.

He sits in the containment and experiences the texture of the present.

It is, unexpectedly, interesting.

INT. KRONOS'S TEMPORAL CONTAINMENT – LATER – JOSEPH ARRIVES

Strange opens a narrow channel in the containment – just enough for conversation, not enough for emergence. Joseph steps through.

They face each other. The being that has been building toward this for ten thousand years. The boy who became what was required of him in fourteen months.

Neither of them speaks for a long moment.

KRONOS

(in the voice of someone
experiencing something new –
without the deliberate weight
of his previous appearances,
without the quality of
something that has been
patient for ten thousand
years and is done being
patient)

I haven't experienced a single moment
in ten thousand years. I've experienced
all of them simultaneously. I'd
forgotten what now feels like.

JOSEPH

What does it feel like?

KRONOS

(genuinely considering this)
Specific. Each second has a quality
I couldn't perceive when all seconds
were equally available. It's like –

looking at a single note rather than
a chord. The chord is more complex.
But the single note has a quality
the chord obscures.

A pause.

KRONOS

I want you to understand that my
intention was never malicious. I
calculated what the multiverse needs
and I built toward it. The calculation
was honest. The method was – the
method produced costs I had categorized
as acceptable.

JOSEPH

My mother.

KRONOS

Was one of the costs I had categorized
as acceptable.

He looks at Joseph directly.

KRONOS

I understand that this is not how
you experience it. I am trying to
understand – now, in this moment,
in this specific present – how you
experience it. I find I have more
access to that question than I did
when I could see all moments
simultaneously.
When all moments are available,
any single moment loses its weight.
I lost the weight of individual
moments.
I lost your mother's weight.

A long pause.

JOSEPH

She called every Sunday. For twenty
years. She watered a fig tree that
took two years to produce three figs

and photographed them and sent the
photographs with the subject line
'it persisted.' She told me to drink
more water than I think I need
because the city is deceptive.
She was a nurse for twenty years.
She cared for people she would never
see again and gave them the specific
thing they needed without asking
for anything in return.

He looks at Kronos.

JOSEPH

That is what I am asking you to
hold as a weight. Not the multiverse.
Not the thirty-two percent. Her.
Specifically.

Kronos is quiet for a long time.

He is experiencing the weight of this specific thing in
this specific present.

KRONOS

(after a while — quietly)
She had a fig tree.

JOSEPH

On the south wall. With jasmine
beside it. She told it to persist.

Kronos looks at this. He holds it.

KRONOS

The calculation that produced what
I did — the calculation that called
her a cost — I ran that calculation
for ten thousand years. I believed
it was correct. I still believe
the arithmetic was correct.

A pause.

KRONOS

The premise is where I was wrong.
The premise was that any loss can
be justified by a sufficiently large
benefit. The premise failed to account
for the thing that makes any benefit
meaningful. The fig tree that took
two years to produce three figs
and was photographed and sent with
the subject line 'it persisted' –
that is not a data point. That is
the reason the data points matter.
You cannot calculate the value of
what makes calculation meaningful.

Joseph looks at him.

JOSEPH

You said that.

KRONOS

I needed to hear it in this specific
present. With this specific weight.
To understand it rather than know it.

A long pause.

JOSEPH

What happens to you now?

KRONOS

I remain here until the institutions
of the multiverse – the ones your
organization represents – determine
what is appropriate. I have no
objection to this. I spent ten
thousand years imposing arrangements
on things that didn't want to be
arranged. It is appropriate that
I experience, for some time, an
arrangement I didn't choose.

He looks at Joseph with the specific expression of
something that has just learned something genuinely new.

KRONOS

Tell me about the fig tree.

Joseph looks at him. He considers. He sits down on the floor of the containment, because there is nowhere else to sit and the conversation is not done.

He tells him about the fig tree.

He tells him about the jasmine on the south wall, and the specific fragrance that reached the kitchen window every spring. He tells him about the Sunday calls, and the forty-one-minute average. He tells him about the routing protocol Seiko built, and the Moroccan flag sticker on the spiral notebook, and the instruction to drink more water than you think you need because the city is deceptive.

He tells him about the photograph he found in the kitchen – his parents' wedding, his father young and laughing, his mother looking directly at the camera, composed, complete, not performing anything.

He tells him about standing on the rooftop with Yara, the city below, the Atlantic beyond, the jasmine reaching them even up there, persistent, still itself.

He tells him: she made sure every call was complete. Not as a hedge against mortality – though she understood mortality, she had been a nurse for twenty years and she understood it precisely. She made every call complete because she understood that last times are possible, and she had decided to treat every time accordingly. She had decided to live in a way that she would not regret any of it.

Kronos listens. He holds each detail with the specific weight of a being experiencing the texture of the present for the first time in ten thousand years.

At the end, he says:

KRONOS

(very quietly)

She sounds like someone who understood something I missed.

JOSEPH

She understood that the recurring things are the real things. Not the

large events. The Sunday calls.
The fig tree. The water. The recurring
things say: I'm still here. Regardless.
That's the thing that makes any
percentage meaningful. The
'regardless.'

Kronos holds this.

KRONOS
(after a long time)
Ten thousand years. And I never
accounted for 'regardless.'

Joseph stands. He goes to the channel.

JOSEPH
You'll have time to think about it.

He goes.

FADE OUT.

CUT TO:

WHAT COMES AFTER

THE DAYS FOLLOWING

INT. AL-MITHALI APARTMENT — FATIMA'S KITCHEN — MORNING

Joseph is in Casablanca.

He has been here for three days. He has been here without operational reason, without a briefing to prepare or a threat to analyze or a diagnostic to run. He has been here because the work, for the first time in fourteen months, is at a pause — a genuine pause, not a gap between crises but a completed chapter.

The plants are all alive. He has been watering them every morning. Each one. Carefully. The ficus, the two succulents, the herbs. They are, if anything, doing better than they were. She always said: plants respond to attention. Not the quantity of water — the attention you bring when you give it.

He is sitting at the kitchen table. He has been sitting here for approximately forty minutes. He is not reading. He is not running calculations. He is sitting at his mother's kitchen table, in the morning light that comes through the window she kept the herbs on, and he is just sitting.

HASSAN AL-MITHALI comes in from the other room. He has been here since yesterday — he came when Joseph called, which Joseph will think about later, the specific quality of a father who comes when called without asking why or how long or whether it's convenient.

Hassan sits across from him at the table. He brings two cups of coffee. He sets one in front of Joseph.

Neither of them says anything for a while.

HASSAN

(in Arabic — the Arabic of
someone who learned the
language as the language of

home and has never needed it
to be anything else)
She put a photograph of the three
of us in the kitchen. Did you see it?

JOSEPH

(in Arabic)

Yes. I found it in the first week.
It's from the summer I turned six.
You were trying to teach me to ride
a bicycle and she was watching.

HASSAN

You kept falling off and getting back
up without crying. She said: that's
the one. That's who he's going to be.

A pause.

JOSEPH

She told you that?

HASSAN

That evening. After you'd gone to
bed. She said: he'll fall a lot.
But he'll always get back up.
We just have to make sure he knows
that getting back up is what you do.
Not because you're not hurt. Because
the getting up is the thing.

Joseph holds this.

JOSEPH

Did she ever doubt it?

HASSAN

(simply)

No. That's the thing about your
mother. She made decisions about
people and then she lived by them.
She decided you were going to be
the getting-up kind and then she
treated you as if it were already
true. Because she understood that

how you treat someone has something
to do with who they become.

They drink their coffee.

The morning light on the kitchen window. The herbs. The
figus in the corner.

JOSEPH

The fig tree. Has it – since the fire –

HASSAN

I went yesterday. Before I came here.
The fig tree on the south wall is
still there. The wall needs repair
above the fourth floor. But the fig
tree is still there.

A pause.

HASSAN

She told it to persist. It's listening,
I think.

Joseph looks at his father. He looks at the coffee. He
looks at the morning light.

JOSEPH

(quietly)

I'm going to move back to Casablanca.
Not immediately. But eventually.
Nadia is going to need – and I
want to be where she is. And where
you are.

HASSAN

(looking at him)

Your work.

JOSEPH

The MPA can function from anywhere.
Seiko can function from anywhere.
And I –

He stops. He finds the right words.

JOSEPH

She said: do the work that is in front of you. One thing at a time. The work that is in front of me right now is being where my family is. After that, we see.

Hassan looks at him.

HASSAN

She would have been very specific about the wisdom of that decision. She would have listed its merits in order of importance.

JOSEPH

(almost smiling)

She would have started with the climate. She always started with the practical.

HASSAN

(warmth)

Yes. She would have said: Casablanca is better for you than New York. The light is different. And the tea is already there.

Joseph laughs. It is a real laugh – the specific warmth of someone laughing at something that is funny and is also true and is also about someone they love.

Hassan laughs too.

They sit at the kitchen table in the morning light. They drink their coffee. The plants grow in their usual places. The kitchen continues to be the kitchen.

EXT. CASABLANCA – RUE DES ORANGERS – LATER

The building. The south wall, under repair – scaffolding on the fourth floor where the damage was, workmen moving carefully. The jasmine below the scaffolding, reaching up the wall with the same unhurried determination it has always had.

And: on the wall beside the jasmine, the fig tree. Not large – never large. But there. Its leaves catching the light. Three small figs forming at its lower branches.

Joseph stands on the street and looks at the fig tree for a long time.

He thinks: she told it to persist. It's listening.

He thinks: be water.

He takes out his phone. He calls NADIA.

NADIA

(V.O. – the voice of someone who is fifteen and has decided to handle what cannot be changed by becoming very precisely who she is)

Joseph.

JOSEPH

Are you free for dinner? I'm in the city.

NADIA

(V.O.)

I know you're in the city. Baba told me. Of course I'm free for dinner.

JOSEPH

The restaurant she liked on the corniche. Seven o'clock?

NADIA

(V.O. – quiet, specific)

She would have liked that.

JOSEPH

Yes. She would have.

He closes the phone. He looks at the fig tree one more time.

He says, very quietly, in Arabic, not for anyone to hear:

JOSEPH
(in Arabic)
Thank you. For persisting.

He goes.

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — MONITORING ROOM — MUCH LATER

The monitoring room at night. The screens cycling. The mint tea. SEIKO at his station — he is on his second week of proper shoulder treatment, which means he is working at eighty percent of his usual intensity instead of his usual one hundred and fifteen, and has had to accept Darwin's assessment that the difference in output quality is not measurable.

Darwin is in the adjacent chair. He is not pretending to be doing something else. He is just there. This has become, in the two weeks since the Swiss Alps extraction, the normal configuration. Nobody has commented on it.

GUMBALL is somewhere in the building with Darwin's full knowledge of his location, which Gumball is also aware of, which has become a kind of joke between them that is also not a joke at all.

JOSEPH arrives. He has been in Casablanca for three days. He looks different — not visibly, but in the specific way that three days in the right place does to a person.

He goes to his station. He opens his notebook. He picks up his pen.

He does not write WHAT WE KNOW or WHAT MATTERS. He writes a date. And then:

THE WORK CONTINUES.

He closes the notebook.

He picks up his cup of mint tea — warm, fresh, the standing supply order from the Casablanca importer that nobody has thought to change and that nobody will change.

He drinks it.

He thinks: she was right about the tea. It counts.

He thinks about Sunday. He calls his father. He calls Nadia. He is going to call them every Sunday from now on. Not as a protocol – as the recurring thing. As the structure. As the thing that says: I'm still here. Regardless.

The screens cycle. The mint tea is warm. The work is in front of him.

He begins.

FADE OUT.

SMASH CUT TO:

EXTENDED SEQUENCE: EPSTEIN'S FINAL CALCULATION

INT. EPSTEIN'S SECONDARY FACILITY — NIGHT — SIMULTANEOUS WITH THE CRYSTAL SEQUENCE

JEFFREY EPSTEIN sits in the room with the view of the harbor. The window is dark — it is past midnight — but he keeps it unshuttered because even in the dark the presence of the open water is useful. It reminds him that from any shore, departure is always possible.

He is, for the first time in many years, without his network. He knew this was coming. He planned for it. Not the specific timing — that was sooner than he expected, the boy was more efficient than he modeled — but the fact of it. He has known for eight months that if the weapon Seiko Toast identified as theoretically possible were to be constructed from the Weezy Gold material he identified in the in-between records, the network would dissolve.

He spent those eight months doing two things simultaneously. The first: implementing his plan at maximum speed, completing the phases that needed the network before it was gone. The second: building what comes after.

The network is a system built on leverage. Leverage is powerful but brittle — it depends on the thing being leveraged remaining afraid of the revelation. The moment the revelation happens — the moment the information is simply out, known, no longer secret — the leverage dissolves. He has always known this. He built the network understanding its brittleness precisely, and he spent thirty years maintaining the secrecy that kept it operational.

Now the secrecy is gone. The files are public. The accounts are exposed. The twenty-three nodes have been, in the technical language of his operational architecture, emancipated.

He sits with this.

He is not destroyed by it. He has never built a system without building a successor system. The network was the second-generation architecture — the first was more crude, built in his twenties, dismantled voluntarily when he

understood its limitations. The third generation has been in construction for eight months. It does not depend on leverage.

It depends on something more durable: knowledge. Not the knowledge of what powerful people have done — that is leverage, and leverage is brittle. The knowledge of what powerful people want. What they fear. What they would give a very great deal to achieve. This is different from leverage because it cannot be dissolved by revelation. What someone wants does not stop being what they want when the knowledge of their wanting becomes public.

The third generation is in early operation. It will take four years to reach maturity. He has four years.

His phone rings. It is the contact inside the MPA's outer security layer — the one he has maintained through three generations of the organization's personnel — calling to tell him what he already knows: the crystal is gone, the network is dissolved, the MPA team is returning to headquarters.

He listens. He confirms the information. He closes the phone.

He picks up a different phone. He makes a call to the first node of the third-generation architecture. The call is brief. It establishes that the node is operational and that the transition from network-based leverage to want-based cultivation is proceeding on schedule.

He sits back.

He thinks about the boy.

He thinks: I told him the truth about the center crystal. I told him the map was in the accounts, which it was. I gave him the specific information he needed to do the thing I needed him to do. This was not generosity — it was architecture. I used him to achieve my objective, which was the dissolution of Kronos's plan, which required the dissolution of my own network. I sacrificed the second-generation architecture to protect the third-generation architecture.

He thinks: and he knows this. The boy understands that he was used. He came to the facility knowing he was walking into a room where he would receive exactly the information

I wanted him to have. He came anyway because the information was worth it and because walking into the room knowingly is different from walking in unknowingly.

He thinks: that is an interesting quality. The ability to use the information given by an adversary while knowing it is being given deliberately. Most people cannot do this – they either refuse the information because it comes from the wrong source, or they accept it and are fully used. The boy accepted it and was used and used it. Three things simultaneously.

Epstein has not encountered many people who can do three things simultaneously and know they are doing all three.

He thinks: four years. The third-generation architecture reaches maturity in four years. The boy will have four years to prepare.

He goes to the window. The harbor. The dark water. The lights of boats at anchor, swaying slightly.

He thinks: the architecture is always already in place before anyone knows to look. That is what makes it architecture and not just a plan.

He picks up the phone. He calls the second node of the third-generation architecture.

He goes to work.

CUT TO:

EXTENDED SEQUENCE: THE HEROES AFTER

VARIOUS LOCATIONS — THE DAYS FOLLOWING THE CRYSTAL

INT. STARK TOWER — TONY STARK'S LAB — NIGHT

TONY STARK sits in his lab at two in the morning, which is not unusual, doing something that is not work, which is very unusual.

He is looking at a photograph on his phone. It is a photograph of himself that he did not take and did not know was being taken — taken during the Battle of Kilimanjaro, at the summit's eastern edge, during the third hour of combat. In the photograph, Tony Stark is mid-flight, the Iron Man suit processing seventeen simultaneous tactical inputs, at approximately five hundred meters above the mountain. The specific quality of the photograph is that it catches the suit in a moment of absolute precision — every system calibrated, every vector calculated, the technology at its most complete expression.

He is looking at this photograph because SEIKO sent it to him this morning with a note that said: I thought you would want to know that the suit performed with zero deviation from optimal parameters for eleven hours and forty minutes at altitude. I don't know if anyone has told you that.

Nobody had told him that. PEPPER had told him he came home. MORGAN had told him he was big. Rhodey had told him the suit took a beating but held. Nobody had said: eleven hours. Zero deviation.

He looks at the photograph.

He thinks about what it means to build something and have it perform at zero deviation for eleven hours and forty minutes at 5,895 meters. He thinks about the specific, accumulated work of making something that does what it is supposed to do when the conditions are exactly the worst they could be.

He thinks: Seiko noticed. The kid noticed. He runs data streams on everything simultaneously and somewhere in all

of that data he noticed that the suit performed at zero deviation and decided that this was worth saying to the person who built the suit.

Tony closes the photograph. He opens a new design file. He starts working on the next version of the suit – the one that accounts for what Kilimanjaro showed him about sustained high-altitude performance in temporal anomaly conditions. He has been putting this off for two weeks. He starts now.

At four in the morning, he sends Seiko a message: thank you for noticing.

At four-oh-two in the morning, Seiko sends back: the next version of the suit should address the thermal variance issue in the left shoulder joint. I flagged it at hour seven. I have data.

At four-oh-three, Tony is already pulling the data.

EXT. ASGARD – THOR'S HALL – DAWN

THOR stands at the edge of the bridge that overlooks the Asgardian sea and thinks about what Wolverine said during the Paris battle: when you show up, you show up.

He has been thinking about this for three weeks. Not because it is complicated – it is not complicated – but because it is true in a way that he has not been told before, and the truth of it has a quality he wants to understand.

He has spent three thousand years being the god of thunder in the specific sense of being the most powerful thing in a room and knowing it. He has spent those three thousand years understanding his own power as an individual phenomenon – as Thor's power, specific to Thor, existing in Thor.

What he has learned, in fourteen months of working beside sixty people from every tradition and dimension and capability set, is that power understood as an individual phenomenon is a fraction of power understood as a relational phenomenon. His lightning through the iron infrastructure of Paris was not his lightning. It was his lightning plus the infrastructure plus the knowledge that the infrastructure would conduct it plus the tactical

analysis that identified Paris as the theater where this specific combination would be effective. It was, in other words, Joseph Al-Mithali's analysis meeting Thor's lightning meeting Haussmann's architecture meeting two centuries of Parisian metallurgical development.

He thinks: I have been the most powerful thing in rooms for three thousand years. And I have been less powerful than I am now.

He goes back inside. He writes a letter – in Asgardian, which he will translate later – to the MPA. He says: I have been thinking about what it means to be in the right room. I would like to remain in this one.

INT. GOTHAM CITY – BATMAN'S STUDY – NIGHT

BATMAN – Bruce Wayne, sitting in the study of Wayne Manor in civilian clothes, reviewing what is not a threat assessment and is not a tactical analysis and is not a briefing document – is reviewing the after-action reports from all five city battles, from the Swiss Alps ambush, from Kilimanjaro, from the crystal operation.

He does this after every operation. He always has. It is the specific discipline of someone who understands that the most important work happens after the event, in the space where what worked and what didn't work become information for what comes next.

What is different about this review: he is not looking at what the team did. He is looking at what Joseph Al-Mithali did.

Specifically: the decisions made under conditions of acute grief. The specific quality of operational judgment exercised by a person carrying an enormous personal loss through fourteen months of escalating crisis.

He has studied exceptional individuals for twenty years. He has studied what makes the exceptional exceptional – the specific combination of capability and character that produces someone who can function at the level that the situation requires. He has met a small number of such people. He has worked beside fewer.

Joseph Al-Mithali is something he has not encountered before: exceptional at the specific intersection of

operational intelligence and relational awareness. The two things that are most frequently incompatible – the analytical distance required to make good operational decisions and the relational presence required to hold together the team that executes those decisions – coexist in him without apparent tension.

Batman thinks: the coexistence is not natural. It was built. It was built by a woman who called every Sunday and told her son to drink more water than he thinks he needs and photographed the fig tree when it produced three figs and wrote 'it persisted' in the subject line.

He closes the after-action files. He opens a different file – his personal notes, the ones nobody sees. He writes:

'Fatima Al-Mithali. Nurse. Casablanca. The work she did will outlast the network Epstein built and the architecture Kronos constructed. Both of those required force to maintain. Her work required only the recurring things. Sunday calls. Fig trees. Water.'

He closes the file.

He goes back to work.

INT. HARRY'S FLAT – LONDON – MORNING

HARRY POTTER wakes up. This is not remarkable. What is remarkable is the quality of the waking – the specific, uncomplicated clarity of someone who has slept fully and completely, without the particular weight that has been present for him since the war ended and the specific kind of unfinished business that wars leave behind settled into his bones.

Something is different.

He sits on the edge of the bed. GINNY is still asleep. He looks at the morning light coming through the window – London light, grey and specific – and tries to identify what is different.

He had the dream. Not the nightmare – the other one. The one where he is standing in a specific field in what feels like summer and everything is fine. He has been having the nightmare for twenty years. He cannot remember the last time he had the other one.

He thinks: Voldemort's wand is ash on the Thames. He has known this for weeks. He has known it intellectually for weeks. This morning is the first morning it feels true in the way that true things feel true — not as information, but as the texture of the present.

He gets up. He makes tea. He sits at the kitchen table and thinks about what YARA GORDON said, in a brief conversation during the post-Kilimanjaro debrief, about the difference between knowing something is over and experiencing it as over. She said: the integration takes longer than the event. Give it time. The time is doing something even when it doesn't feel like it.

He drinks his tea. He thinks: she was right. The time was doing something.

He picks up his phone. He sends Hermione a message: I slept. Fully. For the first time. I thought you would want to know.

She responds in eleven seconds: I know. Ron told me. I'm glad. Have tea.

He already has tea. He has it again.

CUT TO:

EXTENDED SEQUENCE: SEIKO AND ISABELLA

MPA HEADQUARTERS — THE SECOND WEEK

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — ANALYSIS CORRIDOR — AFTERNOON

SEIKO finds ISABELLA in the analysis corridor.

This is not an accident. He has been finding specific moments to be in the same location as Isabella for five days, in the way of someone who has something to say and is identifying the correct conditions for saying it. The correct conditions: not in the monitoring room where every screen is running. Not in the briefing room where there are always people. A corridor, in the afternoon, when the specific quality of light through the high windows creates a particular atmosphere that Seiko's analytical mind recognizes as conducive to conversations that matter.

Isabella is reading a file. She is always reading a file. She reads files with the complete attention of someone who has spent decades learning to observe and who applies that observational capability to everything, including documents.

Seiko stands in the corridor for a moment, organizing what he wants to say. He has been organizing it for five days.

SEIKO

I've been running the temporal data
from the Time Tracker analysis.
I found something I want to discuss
with you. Not with the full team.
With you specifically.

Isabella looks up from the file. She looks at him with the full, undivided attention that is, Seiko has found, slightly disconcerting to be on the receiving end of — the attention of someone who is genuinely interested in what you say and who has no social agenda complicating the interest.

ISABELLA

Tell me.

SEIKO

The tracking data extends back further than the Cambridge vortex. Much further. The earliest record I can find of someone monitoring Joseph Al-Mithali specifically is from approximately two years before Cambridge. Which means the tracking began before there was anything to track – before he was who he became. Before the event that made him what he is.

Isabella watches him.

SEIKO

But that's not the part I wanted to discuss. The part I wanted to discuss is the following.

He pulls up a data visualization on the tablet he's been carrying. It shows a timeline – marked with events from the past fourteen months – overlaid with another set of markers in a different color.

SEIKO

The letter arrived four days before the Cambridge vortex. Four days. It said: he will strike at what you love before he strikes at you. Four days before the event that made that sentence meaningful. Before there was a 'you' for someone to strike at. Before there was a 'what you love' in the operational sense.

He looks at her.

SEIKO

The letter was sent from a position of knowing what would happen. Not predicting – knowing. Which means the sender either has temporal capability that allows observation

of future events, or the sender was present at the decision point that caused the future events and knew what was going to happen because they were part of what made it happen.

A pause.

SEIKO

If it's the first option: the sender is something with temporal observational capability. If it's the second option: the sender knew about the vortex in advance and decided to warn Joseph rather than prevent it. Which would mean the sender believed the vortex needed to happen. Which would mean the sender made a choice that is structurally identical to the choice your father made.

Isabella looks at him.

SEIKO

The difference being that your father decided not to warn. The sender of the letter decided to warn but not to prevent. Which is a third position – between full intervention and pure observation. A position that says: I cannot change what's coming. But I can give you the information to survive it.

A long pause.

ISABELLA

(quietly)

That's a very specific analysis.

SEIKO

Yes. It took five days.

Isabella looks at the visualization on the tablet.

SEIKO

I'm not asking you to confirm or deny. I'm telling you what the data shows because I believe you should know that I've seen it. And because I believe that you made that choice deliberately and carefully and with full understanding of its cost. And I wanted to say: thank you. For making the third choice.

Isabella is quiet for a moment.

ISABELLA

You're very precise.

SEIKO

Yes. I've been told this. It is sometimes useful and sometimes not. In this case I believed it was the right approach.

ISABELLA

It was.

A pause. The afternoon light through the high windows.

ISABELLA

What made you decide to tell me now?

SEIKO

The analysis was complete five days ago. I waited because I was identifying the correct conditions for the conversation. I wanted a corridor. With afternoon light.

Isabella looks at him. Something shifts in her expression — the specific shift of someone who has just encountered something unexpected and is deciding what to do with it.

ISABELLA

Why a corridor with afternoon light?

SEIKO

The acoustic properties are better than the monitoring room. The social pressure is lower than the briefing room. And the afternoon light has a quality that I have found, over fourteen months at this station, is conducive to conversations that need to be honest.

Isabella looks at him for a long moment.

ISABELLA

You are a very specific kind of person.

SEIKO

(simply)

Yes. I've been told this too.

She closes the file she was reading. She looks at the visualization on his tablet.

ISABELLA

Tell me what else the data shows.

He tells her. She listens with complete attention. The afternoon light does its work.

CUT TO:

EXTENDED SEQUENCE: GUMBALL AND DARWIN

MPA HEADQUARTERS — THE FIRST WEEK

INT. MPA HEADQUARTERS — COMMON ROOM — EVENING

GUMBALL WATTERSON sits in the common room with a cup of hot chocolate he has been nursing for approximately forty minutes. This is not unusual. What is unusual is that he is not talking. Gumball is almost always talking — talking or moving or doing something with the specific, restless energy of someone for whom stillness has always been a temporary condition.

Tonight he is still.

DARWIN finds him here. Darwin always finds him. Darwin has a specific sensory awareness of Gumball's location that he would describe, if asked, as nothing remarkable, just paying attention, because Darwin is honest and honest people say things like that about capabilities that are actually remarkable.

Darwin sits beside him. He does not say anything for a while. He also has a cup of hot chocolate, which appeared in his hands somewhere between the door and the seat and which Darwin will not comment on because some things are better not commented on.

After a while:

GUMBALL

(not looking away from the
middle distance)

I was in that room for six weeks.
Six weeks of talking to you through
a vent.

DARWIN

Yes.

GUMBALL

The room was comfortable. That was the part that bothered me the most. That it was comfortable. Because it meant that whoever built it understood that a comfortable cage is harder to resist than an uncomfortable one. A comfortable cage says: you could stay here. Look how comfortable.

DARWIN

But you didn't.

GUMBALL

I had you through the vent.

A pause.

GUMBALL

(still looking at the middle distance)

I told Yara about you. Everything. The way you hum when you're thinking. The head tilt when something makes you sad. The thing you do where you position yourself slightly between me and whatever might be a problem without making it look intentional.

DARWIN

It's not intentional. It's just where I end up.

GUMBALL

I know. That's why I told her about it. Because the things that happen without being intentional are the most honest things about a person.

Darwin looks at him.

DARWIN

You were more comfortable than I was. Out here. Without knowing where you

were or if you were —

He stops.

DARWIN

(continuing, more quietly)
Six weeks.

GUMBALL

I know. I'm sorry.

DARWIN

You don't need to be sorry. You
didn't choose to be taken. I just —
six weeks is a long time to not know.

A pause.

GUMBALL

What did you do? While I was gone?

DARWIN

(after a moment)

I helped. I kept the civilians safe
during the city battles. I fed Seiko
every three hours because Batman
told me to and also because someone
needed to. I held a child's hand
under Tower Bridge for forty-seven
minutes while Harry fought Voldemort.
I found the specific moment when
Seiko's shoulder needed treatment
and treated it.

A pause.

DARWIN

And I counted the days. Every one.

Gumball looks at him for the first time since Darwin sat
down.

GUMBALL

(simply)

Thank you for counting.

DARWIN

Every one.

They drink their hot chocolate. The common room continues around them – screens running, someone making tea in the corner, the specific ambient hum of a building where a lot of important things happen all the time.

GUMBALL

(after a while)

I kept you alive in there.
In the room. I told Yara every
detail I could remember about you
so you would stay real in the
space between us. The humming.
The head tilt. The position thing.

DARWIN

(quietly)

I kept you alive out here the
same way. I talked about you.
Joseph asked how you were managing
and I told him: he's managing.
He's doing all the pushups he can.

Gumball almost smiles.

GUMBALL

More than zero. Less than I'd like.

DARWIN

That's the right approach.

They sit in the common room. The hot chocolate is now fully cold. Neither of them has moved. This is fine. This is, in fact, exactly right.

CUT TO:

EXTENDED SEQUENCE: THE LETTER'S AUTHOR

THE IN-BETWEEN – BEFORE CAMBRIDGE – THREE YEARS AGO

INT. THE WATCHER'S PALACE – ISABELLA'S ROOM – NIGHT (THREE YEARS BEFORE CAMBRIDGE)

ISABELLA is twenty-two years old in this memory – she has been twenty-two for a while, in the way of things that exist in the in-between, where time operates differently – and she is at a desk, looking at a piece of paper.

The paper is from no catalogued dimension. She has been assembling it for three months from materials accumulated at the center of the in-between – paper from a dimension that no longer exists, ink old in ways that don't correspond to any single timeline. She has been assembling it because she knows what she is going to write, and she knows that what she writes will need to carry across a gap in time to a person who does not yet exist in the form he will have when he reads it.

She has been watching Joseph Al-Mithali for two years.

Not his present – she cannot see his present, because his present is before the event that will make him who he will become. She has been watching what he will become. The specific trajectory of a person from Cambridge undergraduate to the Director of the MPA, as it appears in the temporal lattice: not guaranteed, not inevitable, but with the specific quality of something that is trying to happen, that is reaching toward its form the way a plant reaches toward light.

She has been watching, and she has seen what is coming: the vortex. Her father's choice. The barrier collapse. The first war. The second war. The cost. The specific cost.

She has watched her father make his decision and she has understood it – the logic of it, the math of it, the specific calculation that says: controlled failure with a stabilizing force at the center is better than uncontrolled catastrophic failure. She has understood it and she has

watched it and she has not intervened, because intervention is not what she does. Observation is what she does.

Until tonight.

Tonight she is going to write a letter.

Not because she can prevent what is coming – she cannot. The vortex will happen. The barrier will collapse. The first war will happen. The second war will happen. The cost will be paid. She cannot change any of this.

But she can give him the specific piece of information that will allow him to survive paying the cost. She can tell him, four days before the event that will make the information meaningful, what the adversary's strategy is. He will strike at what you love before he strikes at you.

She can give him this.

She picks up the pen.

She thinks: this is the third position. Not full intervention, not pure observation. The position that says: I cannot change what is coming. But I can give you what you need to survive it.

She thinks: my father chose not to tell him. My father chose to use him as a stabilizing force without his knowledge. I am choosing to tell him something. Not everything – she cannot tell him everything, the information would be too much, it would change what he becomes in ways that would make him less able to survive it. But one specific thing. The adversary's strategy.

She thinks: this is where observation ends and involvement begins. This is the line I am crossing.

She crosses it.

She writes:

TO JOSEPH AL-MITHALI, DIRECTOR OF THE MULTIVERSAL PROTECTION AGENCY:

A second war is coming. It is already being planned by someone who has been thinking about it for a very long time. He understands you well enough to know that the most

effective approach is not to attack you directly but to attack the people who make you possible.

He will strike at what you love before he strikes at you.

This is not a warning you can fully act on yet. The event that makes this warning meaningful has not yet happened. When it happens, remember this letter. Remember that you were told. Remember that the people who make you possible are the architecture of what you are, and that the architecture can be protected if you know to protect it.

You will not know who sent this. That is appropriate. What matters is that you know it was sent – that someone saw what was coming and decided that you deserved to know enough to survive it.

Drink water. The city is deceptive.

She pauses at the last line. She looks at it.

She has been watching him for two years. In two years of watching, the most consistent thing about him – across every timeline variant she has been able to observe – is the specific relationship with his mother. The Sunday calls. The instructions about water and screen time. The fig tree updates.

She doesn't know how she knows to include this. She knows it is right.

She seals the letter. She creates the temporal delivery mechanism – a fold in the in-between that will deposit the letter in the specific location, at the specific time, four days before the Cambridge vortex. She calibrates it with the precision of someone who has been observing temporal mechanics for decades.

She holds the sealed letter for a moment.

She thinks: this is not enough. Everything that's coming – the cost of all of it – this one letter is not enough. She knows this.

She thinks: but it is what I can do. And what I can do is what I will do.

She releases the letter into the temporal fold.

She watches it go.

She sits at the desk for a long time afterward. The in-between outside her window. The specific silence of a place at the center of everything, where everything is happening and nothing of it can be heard.

She picks up her pen again.

She starts a new page.

She begins to write the record of what she has seen — everything she has observed, organized into a document that no one will read for three years, that will become the file Seiko Toast identifies in the temporal data as the evidence of someone watching Joseph Al-Mithali from the beginning.

She writes: his name is Joseph Al-Mithali. He is studying at Cambridge. He drinks mint tea. He calls his mother every Sunday. The call lasts on average forty-one minutes.

She writes: he is going to be the stabilizing force at the center of everything. He doesn't know this yet. He won't know this for a long time. But he's already the person who will be that. It's already in how he pays attention.

She writes: I have decided to stop only observing.

She writes until dawn.

CUT TO:

EXTENDED SEQUENCE: HASSAN AL-MITHALI

CASABLANCA — THE WEEKS AFTER

INT. AL-MITHALI APARTMENT — HASSAN'S STUDY — NIGHT

HASSAN AL-MITHALI, fifty-four years old, sits in his study at eleven at night going through the papers on his desk. He has been sitting here for an hour. He has been going through the same stack of papers for the last twenty minutes without progressing, because he is not really going through the papers. He is thinking.

He is thinking about what Joseph said at dinner last week: I'm going to come back to Casablanca. Not immediately. Eventually. I want to be where the family is.

Hassan has been thinking about this sentence for seven days. Not about whether it is the right decision — he believes, with the specific certainty of someone who has thought carefully about something, that it is exactly the right decision. He has been thinking about the sentence because of the way Joseph said it. Not as a plan. As a fact. As something already true.

He thinks about the specific quality of his son's determination. It is not his own determination — Hassan's determination is practical, built from the accumulated experience of twenty years of teaching students and thirty years of marriage and a lifetime of doing the work that is in front of him without fanfare. His determination has the texture of water: it finds the path, it does not force one.

Joseph's determination has a different texture. He has always had it — since he was six years old, falling off the bicycle and getting back up without crying, and Fatima said: that's the one, that's who he's going to be. The determination of someone who has decided something and then lives as if the decision is already done. As if the future he has committed to is already real.

Fatima used to say: he gets the certainty from you. The stubbornness is mine.

He sits with this.

He thinks about her. He does this every night – not the grief of it, not the hole of it, but the specific practice of remembering her as she was. He has developed this practice over the weeks since: not allowing the last thing to be the last thing. Keeping the fuller picture.

He remembers: the way she moved in the kitchen, with the specific efficiency of someone who has been doing the same tasks for decades and has refined them into a kind of choreography. The way she kept a notebook of her patients – not medical notes, those were at the hospital, these were the human details, the things that mattered about each person as a person. The way she talked to the plants as if they were colleagues. The way she said Joseph's name – in Arabic, with the specific weight of someone who chose that name deliberately and has never regretted it.

He remembers the fig tree. He remembers going to look at it, the week after everything, and standing on the street and looking at it and understanding something he had not understood before: that the thing she cared for is still here. Still reaching. Still producing, in its unhurried way, the specific fruit of persistent attention.

He picks up his phone. It is eleven at night in Casablanca, which is eleven at night in New York. He calls Joseph anyway. Joseph picks up immediately.

HASSAN

(in Arabic)

You're awake.

JOSEPH

(V.O., in Arabic)

I'm always awake at eleven. You know this.

HASSAN

I know. I called anyway.

JOSEPH

(V.O.)

I know. I picked up.

A pause. The specific quality of a phone call between a father and son who do not need to fill the silence.

HASSAN

I went to see the fig tree this morning. It has three new figs. Not the same three. New ones.

JOSEPH

(V.O. - quietly)
She told it to persist.

HASSAN

It's listening.

A long pause.

JOSEPH

(V.O.)
Baba.

HASSAN

Yes.

JOSEPH

(V.O.)
Thank you. For being the kind of person who calls at eleven at night to tell me about the fig tree.

HASSAN

Thank you for being the kind of person who picks up.

Another pause.

HASSAN

She was very proud of you. Not because of what you did. Because of how you did it. The distinction mattered to her.

JOSEPH

(V.O.)
I know.

HASSAN
She said once: the what is just
the circumstance. The how is the
person.

A long pause.

JOSEPH
(V.O. - quietly)
I'll be back in Casablanca in two
weeks. Can I stay at the apartment?

HASSAN
You can stay at the apartment
as long as you want. It is your
apartment.

JOSEPH
(V.O.)
It's her apartment.

HASSAN
(after a moment)
Yes. It's her apartment. You can
stay there anyway. She would have
wanted that.

JOSEPH
(V.O.)
I know. Sunday.

HASSAN
Sunday.

He closes the phone.

He goes back to the papers on his desk. This time he goes
through them. He processes twelve applications for the
third cohort of the Saturday program - forty-one students
in the second cohort, the waiting list has grown to sixty.
He will need to expand. He is already thinking about how.

This is the work that is in front of him. He does it.

CUT TO:

EXTENDED SEQUENCE: THE CITY BATTLES — EXPANDED

FIVE SCREENS — DEEPER INTO THE DETAIL

NEW YORK — EMPIRE STATE BUILDING — THE MOMENT BEFORE

CLOSE ON: Joseph's face in the four seconds before the fight begins. The rooftop. The city below. The specific quality of altitude — the way the city looks from here, its density suggesting something about the relationship between people and proximity, the density of humanity choosing to be close to other humanity.

He thinks: she said the city is deceptive. She meant it practically — the heat and the noise create a sense of busyness that substitutes for hydration and rest. But standing here, in the four seconds before the fight begins, the sentence has a different quality.

The city is deceptive: it looks permanent from here. It looks like the kind of thing that has always existed and will continue to exist regardless of what happens on any individual rooftop. And there is something true about this — the city will outlast any individual event — but there is something false about the comfort this provides, because the city is made of the people in it, and the people in it are not permanent, and the city's permanence is an abstraction that has no warmth.

He thinks: drink more water than you think you need. Because the city is deceptive. Because the thing that looks solid isn't always.

He squares.

He goes.

LONDON — TOWER BRIDGE — DARWIN AND THE CHILD

Expanded sequence: the child's name is MAYA. She is six years old. She is from a family that did not evacuate because her mother does not speak English well enough to have understood the evacuation announcement and her father

was not home and the neighbors who would normally help were also gone.

DARWIN finds them – mother, Maya, and Maya's older brother AMIR, eight – in the shelter of the stone abutment. He sits with them. He has the specific capability, developed through years of being a person who looks different from other people and has had to figure out how to communicate trust quickly, of communicating trust quickly.

Maya asks him what he is. He tells her: I'm a person. She looks at him skeptically. He says: I know. It's a lot to take in.

She accepts this. She puts her hand in his. She keeps it there for forty-seven minutes.

He talks to them about the Thames. He knows a great deal about the Thames – Seiko once ran a comprehensive data analysis of London's waterways at Darwin's request, because Darwin had a period of intense interest in rivers and Seiko honors Darwin's intense interests by providing comprehensive data. He tells them about the eels in the Thames – there are more than people think, and they have been there longer than the bridge above them – and about the specific tidal pattern that means the same water passes under this bridge twice a day, going out and coming back.

The mother, whose name is AMINA, speaks enough English to understand the general shape of what he is saying. She watches him talk to her children with the specific attention of someone assessing a stranger and reaching a conclusion.

At the forty-seven-minute mark, the battle above concludes. Darwin helps them out from under the bridge. Amina thanks him in a combination of English and her first language. He responds in his first language, which is almost the same as hers, which makes her laugh – surprised, genuine.

Maya lets go of his hand. She waves goodbye. He waves back.

He thinks: this is the work. Not the fighting. This is the work.

TOKYO – THE PRECISION – EXPANDED

What SEIKO saw on the feeds during the Tokyo operation: IRON MAN and CYBORG, interfacing faster than language, were not simply two entities with complementary capabilities running simultaneous analyses. They were, for twelve minutes and forty seconds, a single computational system – two intelligences that had found the specific frequency at which they could operate as one without either losing its individual character.

Seiko logged this. He logged it because he has been thinking, since the Cambridge vortex, about the specific question of what the Ideal is – not as a role, not as a responsibility, but as a phenomenon. And what he observes in the Tokyo feeds is: the Ideal is a condition. A condition in which two separate things discover that they are more coherent together than apart. Joseph Al-Mithali, at his most effective, creates this condition. Not by doing it – by being the kind of person around whom it happens.

Tony Stark and Cyborg had never operated at this level of integration before. They will again. The thing that made it possible the first time is now in their capability set.

Seiko logs: Joseph did not do this. Joseph created the conditions in which this could happen. This is the distinction.

He flags this note for the after-action report. He labels it: THE ARCHITECTURE OF PERMISSION – BENIGN VERSION.

He thinks Yara will find this interesting.

He sends it to her. She responds in four minutes: you're right. I'm adding it to the third edition.

CUT TO:

EXTENDED SEQUENCE: NADIA

CASABLANCA — THE EVENING JOSEPH RETURNS

INT. RESTAURANT — CORNICHE — CASABLANCA — EVENING

The restaurant his mother liked. A specific table, near the window that looks out over the Atlantic — the table she always requested, not because it was the best table in the restaurant but because the light at this hour from this angle was, she said, the specific light that makes every conversation feel like it matters.

JOSEPH, HASSAN, and NADIA. Three people in the space where four people used to be.

The waiter — who knew Fatima Al-Mithali by name, who she knew by name, who spent three minutes talking to Hassan about the specific properties of the evening's catch before bringing the menus — sets down a fourth glass of water. Looks at it. Looks at Hassan. Picks it up again, gently, without saying anything. Goes.

NADIA is watching this.

She is fifteen years old and she has her mother's eyes — the specific quality of attention, the way of seeing that processes and holds simultaneously. She has her father's patience. She has, Joseph has noticed, developed in the past months something that belongs to neither of her parents but is entirely her own: a quality of precision. Not analytical precision — something closer to surgical. She identifies exactly what is true and she says exactly that and nothing more.

She says, looking at the space the fourth glass occupied:

NADIA

(in Arabic — the same Arabic
as her mother's)

She would have had the fish. She
always had the fish here. She said
the sauce was the only version that

wasn't trying too hard.

JOSEPH

(in Arabic)

She said that about a lot of things.
That they were trying too hard.

NADIA

She had a specific sensitivity to
effort that didn't match the result.
She said: the effort should be
invisible. If you can see the effort,
it hasn't worked yet.

Hassan smiles. He knows this quality of his daughter — the
way she has been going through her mother's specific
formulations and holding them up to the light of the
present, turning them to see what they reveal.

HASSAN

She said the same thing about the
Saturday program. She said: the
work should look easy even when it's
hard. If the students can see how
hard it is, you haven't prepared
enough.

NADIA

(looking at her father)

Did it look easy?

HASSAN

To them? Yes. To me?

He pauses.

HASSAN

No. But that was the point.

Nadia looks at this. She files it. She turns to Joseph.

NADIA

You're coming back to Casablanca.

JOSEPH

Baba told you.

NADIA

Eventually. Yes.

A pause.

NADIA

She would have wanted that. But she also would have said: don't come back because of me. Come back because it's right for you. She was very specific about the difference between obligation and choice.

JOSEPH

It's a choice.

NADIA

(simply)

Good.

The food comes. The evening light does what it does. The Atlantic beyond the window, continuing its own long business.

They eat. They talk about Nadia's structural dynamics project – she has designed a bridge, notionally, that addresses a specific problem she identified in the existing literature, and she wants Joseph's opinion on the load calculations. He gives it. She disagrees with one point. She is right. He acknowledges this.

They talk about the Saturday program's third cohort. Hassan has decided to expand – a second location, in a different neighborhood, for the students who cannot travel to the first. Nadia has already told three of her classmates about the waiting list.

At the end of the meal, before dessert, Nadia says:

NADIA

(looking at her plate – then up)

I want to say something. I've been
composing it for three weeks.

Joseph and Hassan look at her.

NADIA

She would have wanted us to say:
she was here. Precisely. Fully.
Every Sunday. Every fig tree season.
Every patient. Every plant. Every
cup of tea. She was here the whole
time, and the whole time was real,
and we have it. All of it. Nothing
that was real stops being real
because it ends.

A pause.

NADIA

That's what I wanted to say.

Joseph and Hassan look at each other.

Joseph says, in Arabic, quietly:

JOSEPH

She would have said that was very
precise.

NADIA

(the very slight warmth of
someone receiving exactly the
right response)
Yes. She would have.

They order dessert. They stay until the restaurant closes.
The light changes and changes and finally goes, and the
Atlantic in the dark is a sound and a presence without a
visible edge, and the three of them sit at the specific
table near the window where four people used to sit, and
the conversation continues, because conversations like this
do not really end.

FADE OUT.

